

The Incarnation of the Son

Jesus Christ stands at the very center of the Christian faith. Adherents to this religion are called Christians (rather than, say, Pneumians). Christians believe that Jesus Christ is the turning point of all human history, the most important person to have ever lived, and somehow vital to the welfare and destiny of everyone else. But just who—or what—is Jesus Christ? Is he merely a good religious teacher and moral exemplar who points us to some reality more ultimate than himself? Is he, as Islamic teaching says, one of the greatest prophets but superseded by another? Is he like us—or is he radically different from us? If so, in what ways is he like us or different from us? Is he somehow more than a merely human creature? If so, then what—a hybrid who is neither actually divine nor fully human but rather is something in between, a creature who is also of a lower-ranked divinity, or just what?

Who is Jesus? What difference does he make? Why does he matter so much? And how does he matter? Jesus asked two salient questions about himself: “Who do people say that the Son of Man is?” (Matt 16:13) and “Who do you say that I am?” (Matt 16:15). In this chapter, we shall explore the main elements of this centrally important Christian doctrine. We begin by looking at the classical Christian doctrine of the incarnation. Here we summarize the main lines of Christian doctrine, we show how the core elements of this doctrine are grounded in Scripture, we take a closer look at some of the challenges to (what emerges as) orthodoxy, and we reflect on the meaning and importance of the classical doctrine. Then, tracking closely with the central affirmations of the Apostles’ and Niceno-Constantinopolitan Creeds, we take a closer look at the life and ministry of Jesus Christ.

Again, the question is before us: Just who is this Jesus Christ? Or, as he puts the question, “Who do you say that I am?” (Matt 16:13–15). The answer given by Christian orthodoxy is astounding. It is not that Jesus Christ is a divine being who merely appears to be a first-century Jewish carpenter but was not really human ^[328]after all. Nor is it that he is a merely good but widely and tragically misunderstood man who was specially loved and uniquely adopted by God for special duty. Nor yet is he some lower-ranked deity who is somehow superior to all other creatures while remaining lower than the Creator God. No, the orthodox response is much more radical and indeed nothing less than stunning: Jesus Christ is both really human and really divine. But he is not a hybrid creature who is partly human and partly divine; he is not some sort of amalgamated combination made up of bits and pieces of humanity along with bits and pieces of divinity. No, he is not only human and divine but indeed is *fully* human and *fully* divine.

So Christ is not only a human prophet who enjoyed special favors from God; he is not God in a human-looking disguise; he is not an intermediary creature who has a weaker strain of divinity to go along with his humanity; he is not a composite creature who has some human parts and some divine pieces. What Christians

confess about Christ is something much bolder: They affirm that he is *one person* who is both *fully human* and *fully divine*.

Why do they do this? Why would Christian theologians insist on the option that seems to be the most outrageous and extreme, the one that is sometimes accused of being offensive to sound reason as well as good religion? The short answer is straightforward: Christians confess the faith expressed in the creeds as the surest and best way of encapsulating and summarizing all that is revealed to us about Christ.

8.1. Humanity and Divinity

The humanity of Jesus Christ is on full display in the New Testament, and it is never seriously in doubt. His acquaintances and even his family sometimes have serious questions about him, but they do not ever question the authenticity of his humanity. They sometimes want to know just who does he think he is—but they never ask, Is he really human? The humanity of Christ is attested to in several ways. The genealogies of Jesus (Matt 1:1–17; Luke 3:23–38) bear witness to the fact that he was the descendant of particular human ancestors. They tie him directly not just to humanity in general but to a specifically Jewish lineage and heritage. At the same time, however, they are subversive in complicating simplistic understandings of what counts as Jewish, for the genealogies include people who were not (originally) included but instead were commonly viewed as aliens and even as enemies (e.g., Ruth in Matt 1:5; cf. the references to Ruth “the Moabite” in Ruth 1:22; 2:2, 6, 21). The genealogies also offer a preview of the mission of Christ, for here we see that he is being heralded as the fulfillment^[329] of the prophecies and completion of the promises, and here we see that the one who will save “his people from their sins” (Matt 1:21) has come to rescue those whose lives are marred and broken by sin—regardless of whether they are ethnically Jewish.¹

There is no ambiguity in the gospel accounts—Jesus is fully and completely human. Here we find that he grew and developed from infancy to adulthood (e.g., Luke 1:80; 2:40, 52) and that he worked a trade (Matt 13:55; Mark 6:3). We see that he was hungry (Matt 4:2; 21:18) and thirsty (Matt 25:35; John 19:28) and indeed sometimes exhausted (e.g., Matt 8:24). We cannot miss his very robust emotional life, for he displays compassion (e.g., Matt 9:36; 14:14; 15:32; Luke 13:34; John 11:35) and sorrow (e.g., Matt 23:37; Luke 19:41). He seems to have limited knowledge (e.g., Mark 5:30–33; 13:32). He is overcome by agony and stress in the garden of Gethsemane (Luke 22:42–44) and says that his “soul is overwhelmed with sorrow to the point of death” (Matt 26:37–38 NIV). And make no mistake: He died. John clearly states that “the Word became flesh and lived among us” (John 1:14), and this conviction is echoed in 1 John: “What was from the beginning, what we have heard, what we have seen with our eyes, what we have looked at and touched with our hands, concerning the word of life” (1 John 1:1).²

Similarly, there is rich and ample Pauline witness to the humanity of Christ: “When the fullness of time had come, God sent his Son, born of a woman” (Gal 4:4) who was born “in the likeness of sinful flesh” (Rom 8:3; cf. Rom 1:3–4; 5:6–21; 9:5; 1 Cor 15:1–58; 2 Cor 4:6; 10:1; 13:4; Phil 2:7–8). Paul is convinced that just as “there is one God; there is also one mediator between God and humankind, Christ Jesus, himself human” (1 Tim 2:5). As Stephen T. Davis says, according to Scripture “what the incarnation means is that Jesus Christ is a *person*—a real, living human person. Jesus Christ is not an idea, an ideal, an emanation from God, a divine influence, a principle, a lifestyle, or an ethical principle. These notions are ruled out because what God became was a man (‘and the word became flesh and dwelt among us’).”³

The divinity of Christ, on the other hand, has been the subject of much debate. For monotheists who are committed to the worship of the one true God and who see the one God as the transcendent Creator (e.g., Deut 6:4; Isa 45:23), to confess the divinity of a human person is anything but straightforward and surely runs ^[330] the risks of polytheism and blasphemy. And yet, as we have seen, sober and resolute allegiance to Jesus Christ as the fully divine Son of God just is the Christian orthodoxy that is expressed in the creeds. Why would the earliest Christians and the theologians who shaped the creeds—who were all committed monotheists—affirm that the man Jesus Christ is also divine and offer worship to him?

First, it is important to see that worship indeed is offered to Jesus Christ in earliest Christianity. Stephen T. Davis summarizes the main point:

Prayers addressed to Jesus can be found from the earliest times. It is significant that Greek-speaking churches preserved in Aramaic the cry *Maranatha* (“Our Lord, come!”) (1 Cor 16:22, Didache 10:6); this shows its primitive origin. Personal prayers to Jesus seem to have been commonplace (2 Cor 12:8; 1 Thess 3:11–13; 2 Thess 2:16–17; 3:5; Acts 1:24; 7:59–60). There were also doxologies addressed to Christ, or to Christ and the Father together, although most appear in relatively late NT texts (2 Tim 4:18; 2 Pet 3:18; Rev 1:5–6, 13; cf. 7:10). In earlier texts, doxologies with the phrase “through Jesus Christ” appear (Rom 16:27; cf. 2 Cor 1:20). Hymns of praise to Christ were also common (Phil 2:6–11; 1 Tim 3:16; cf. Eph 5:19; Col 3:16).⁴

Consider, for instance, the direct statement in the exordium to the book of Hebrews: “Let all God’s angels worship him” (Heb 1:6). For any monotheist, there is only one God, and only that God deserves worship. In other words, there is a bright line separating all that is not God from God, and proper worship does not belong to anything or anyone on the not-God side of that line. This text is very significant for the theologians of classical orthodoxy.⁵ The major theologians of the fourth century recognize the prayers to Jesus that are in the New Testament (e.g., 1 Thess 3:11–13; 2 Thess 3:5, 16); for instance, Gregory of Nyssa sees the importance of 1 Tim 3:16 as a doxology that includes Jesus Christ as worshipworthy.⁶

We could readily adduce further examples. Ambrose insists that the Holy Spirit is to be worshiped as “the Son too is worshiped.”⁷ Gregory of Nazianzus approves of the magi’s worship of the infant Jesus as right and good (cf. Matt 2).⁸ Indeed, it ^[331] is not only human persons who rightly worship Jesus as divine; even the angels are called and commanded to do so (e.g., Heb 1:1–4; Rev 5:6–15; 22:20). Commenting on the scenes of worship depicted in the book of Revelation, Richard Bauckham says that “at 15:13 the climax of the throne-vision is reached as the circle of worship expands to encompass the whole creation and the doxology is addressed to both God and the Lamb, uniting the praise of God (Rev 4:9–11) with the praise of the Lamb (Rev 5:9–12) in a single hymn.”⁹ Bauckham concludes that Revelation “places Christ on the divine side of the distinction between God and creation.”¹⁰ The basic point should be clear: Jesus Christ is the recipient of worship in the New Testament, and this worship is widely recognized and affirmed by the theologians of Christian orthodoxy. And the basic argument should be clear as well: For a monotheist, only God is rightly worshiped. Jesus Christ is rightly worshiped. Therefore, Jesus Christ is God.¹¹

Second, it is important to see that the early church recognized the preexistence of Christ. The theologians of creedal orthodoxy argued that John 1 demands that the Word who became flesh has a personal preexistence, for he is not only in the beginning and with God but also was God in and from the very beginning.¹² They argued further that the Son who is the “only begotten” (*monogenēs*) is the only one who has seen God and made God known.¹³ Jesus’s claim to preexist Abraham is especially significant (John 8:58). Again, recent scholarship has done much to deliver further support to this venerable exegetical argument; for instance, some of the “I have

come” statements in the Synoptic Gospels arguably presuppose ^[332]preexistence. ¹⁴ The point, once again, should be clear: A merely human person does not have preexistence. The Word or Son is preexistent. Therefore, the Word or Son is not a merely human person.

Third, and perhaps more important, the theologians wrestling with these issues understood that the person who is Jesus Christ is the one who does the works that only God can do. Christians have always understood that creation is the exclusive act of God, and the New Testament repeatedly and clearly portrays Jesus as the Creator of the cosmos who “sustains all things by his powerful word” (Heb 1:3). For “all things came into being through him, and without him not one thing came into being” (John 1:3). ¹⁵ In Christ, “all things in heaven and on earth were created” (Col 1:16). In the New Testament, Jesus is the final Judge before whom all are accountable and to whom all will give an answer (e.g., Phil 2:10). Indeed, “God, through Jesus Christ, will judge the secret thoughts of all” (Rom 2:16; cf. 2 Thess 1:7–8). To be clear, Jesus takes this role upon himself and, in no uncertain terms, tells his followers that he will separate those who go to “eternal punishment” from those who go to “eternal life” (Matt 25:31–46). Moreover, Scripture makes clear the fact that Jesus Christ is the Savior. Ambrose recognizes this when he says, “The Lord’s cross, then, is my wisdom; the Lord’s death my redemption; for we are redeemed with his precious blood . . . with his blood, then, as man, the Lord redeemed us, who also, as God, has forgiven sins.” ¹⁶ Once more, the basic point should be obvious: Only God is the Creator, Judge, and Redeemer. Jesus Christ is the Creator, Judge, and Redeemer. Therefore, Jesus Christ is God.

Fourth, the theologians of classical orthodoxy saw that the New Testament affirms the unity and equality of Christ with his Father. Key here is Jesus’s own statement that “the Father and I are one” (John 10:30; cf. 17:22); this has been widely understood to reveal his unity and complete equality with his Father. ¹⁷ The ^[333]Son is not of a lesser deity or somehow a lower-ranked god. To the contrary, he is not only preexistent but indeed is one with his Father and wholly equal. Similarly, the angelic announcement that “‘the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and they shall name him Emmanuel,’ which means, ‘God is with us’” (Matt 1:23) is highly significant. ¹⁸ Similarly, the citation of Ps 45:6 with reference to Jesus—“But of the Son he says, ‘Your throne, O God, is forever and ever’” (Heb 1:8)—is seen as a “second testimony to Christ’s deity.” ¹⁹ Indeed, the “whole fullness of deity dwells bodily” in Christ (Col 2:9). ²⁰ As Ambrose says, “He, therefore, possessing the fullness of divinity and glory is not, in respect of his divinity, inferior.” ²¹ Jesus Christ is to be worshiped together with the Father when “at the name of Jesus every knee should bend, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, and every tongue should confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father” (Phil 2:10–11). Hebrews tells us that he is the “reflection of God’s glory and the exact imprint of God’s very being” (Heb 1:3). Athanasius asks, “How is he ‘unlike in substance to the Father,’ seeing that he is the perfect image and brightness of the Father?” ²² Ambrose takes the reflection to be “co-eternal.” ²³ Gregory of Nyssa argues that the “express image” and “exact imprint” must be “the same thing as his essence.” ²⁴

Fifth, the names and titles ascribed to Christ point us directly to his divinity. His favorite self-designation in the Synoptic Gospels is “Son of Man,” and while the debates over the precise meaning and importance of this term are still debated, what is clear is that, in light of the Old Testament background (especially Dan 7:13 KJV), the Son of Man is the one who will bring God’s rule and embody God’s presence with God’s people. ²⁵ In other words, this title is not simply a reminder that he is, after all, really human. It has a much deeper significance for understanding the person and work of Christ. As N. T. Wright says, “Jesus understood his own vocation . . . his own journey to Jerusalem and what he would do there, and supremely in his own death, this long-promised and long-awaited action of ^[334]YHWH.” ²⁶ Similarly, the term “Lord” (*kyrios*) is used regularly and prominently. ²⁷ While the term itself can simply be a term of honor or respect (cf. “sir”), two factors are especially important here. The first is the Old Testament background; the second (and much more important) concerns the actual employment of the term with reference to Christ. The Old Testament background is important but more suggestive than definitive. It is this: The scholars working on the translation of the Old Testament into Greek (the

Septuagint or LXX) used the Greek word for “Lord” (*kyrios*) to translate the most sacred name of God, the Tetragrammaton (YHWH) that was to be protected from profanation. Thus, for readers of the New Testament who were familiar with this usage, there would have been a strong “linguistic bridge” from these christological titles to the God of the Old Testament.²⁸ But while this background is important, the actual usage of the term in the New Testament is much more direct and powerful.

Consider Paul’s statement about the pressing ethical and pastoral concern over eating meat offered to idols: “We know that no ‘idol in the world really exists,’ and that ‘there is no God but one’ . . . yet for us there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things and for whom we exist, and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things and through whom we exist” (1 Cor 8:4–6). What Paul is doing here is striking: He is including Jesus within the Shema (Deut 6:4); he is doing nothing less than including the human Jesus Christ within the life of the one true God.²⁹

Or consider further Paul’s striking inclusion of Jesus within another of the highest statements of monotheism in the Old Testament. In the famous kenosis text, he identifies Jesus as the one who took upon himself the form of a servant and became obedient—even to the point of death on the cross (Phil 2:6–8). But then he also goes on to say, as we have just seen, that “at the name of Jesus every knee should bend” and “every tongue should confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father” (Phil 2:10–11).³⁰ Here Paul is not merely saying that Jesus is above all other humans; he is including him in the prophet Isaiah’s highest [335] statement of monotheism (Isa 45:23) and insisting that Jesus is “Lord” (Yahweh) and thus equal to the Father and yet not to be confused with his Father.

Finally, it is important to understand that the New Testament simply says that Jesus is “God” (*theos*) in several texts (John 1:1, 18; 20:28; Rom 9:5; Titus 2:11; Heb 1:8–9; 2 Pet 1:1). While some of these texts might be debatable (e.g., whether Rom 9:5 refers to Jesus *as* God or Jesus *and* God depends on grammatical details that are not obvious), others are strikingly clear.³¹ Commenting on Thomas’s confession at his encounter with the risen Lord, Athanasius concludes that those who might doubt the divinity of the Son should listen to Thomas, “who handled the crucified and pronounced him Lord and God.”³² And Hilary says that in light of the resurrection, the whole mystery of the faith had become visible to the apostle. Thomas had often heard such words as “I and the Father are one” and “all things that the Father has are mine” and “I am in the Father and the Father is in me,” and now he can confess that the name of God expresses the nature of Christ without peril to the faith. Without breach of loyalty to the one God, the Father, his devotion could now regard the Son of God as God. No longer need he fear that such a confession as his was the proclamation of a second God, a treason against the unity of the divine nature. Hilary concludes that Thomas’s confession was “not a title of honor; it was a confession of nature,” for he “believed that Christ was God in substance and power.”³³

It is important to note that these are not simply names and titles ascribed to Christ, for he claims them for himself and presents himself as God.³⁴ He claims superiority over both Moses and Abraham, and even says, “Very truly, I tell you, before Abraham was, I am” (John 8:58). Note carefully what is happening here. Jesus is not merely claiming preexistence (although he indeed is doing that too). He is claiming for himself the covenant name given in God’s gracious self-revelation, the name that God gives to Moses at the burning bush (Exod 3:14). The importance of this should not be lost on us; it certainly was not missed by the religious leaders who heard it, for they “picked up stones” to use in killing him (John 8:59).

The full—if unexpected and astounding—biblical presentation of Christ calls us to recognize that he is both really and fully human and really and fully divine. But he is not first one and then the other, or somehow two persons—one human and one divine—with a very strong family resemblance. To the contrary, he is one [336] person—one person in two natures, to be sure, but one person nonetheless. He is not two persons in one body; he is not two persons who are indistinguishable. Nor is his personhood formed in relation to his humanity or somehow dependent upon his humanity. He is a single person. **He is a divine person, the Logos and Son who is**

fully personal within the life of the Trinity who becomes human without ceasing to be divine and without splitting himself into two persons. This much is basic to Christian orthodoxy as it is expressed in the creeds and confessions of the church. It constitutes a rich theological inheritance that is affirmed by John and Charles Wesley as well as by nineteenth-century Methodist dogmatic theologians like T. O. Summers and William Burt Pope.³⁵ It is also enshrined in major official Wesleyan and Methodist doctrinal statements such as the Methodist Articles of Religion and the Confession of Faith of the Evangelical United Brethren Church.

8.2. Orthodoxy and Heresy

The challenge to formulate an adequate Christology is both inevitable and daunting. Given the difficulty of holding together the manifold biblical witness to the divinity of the Son along with the obviousness and genuineness of his humanity in the unity of his person, it should not surprise us that various errors have emerged in the development of doctrine (and continue to recur today). Some of these errors (that have been labeled heresies) are committed to the full divinity of Christ at the expense of his humanity. Others are so deeply invested in his genuine humanity that they devalue, degrade, or deny his divinity. And other theories work to retain both divinity and humanity but at the expense of the unity of his personhood.

8.2.1. Docetism

One theory that arose early in the life of the church is known as docetism (from the Greek *dokeō*, “seem” or “appear”). This attempted solution offered an easy fix to the hard conceptual puzzles surrounding the identity of Christ: Simply affirm his divinity and then say that he only seemed to be human or looked human.^[337] This option was defeated for reasons that should be obvious: If there is anything clear about the New Testament portrayals of Jesus, it is that he is really human. In fact, the gospel accounts are completely unashamed not only of his humanity in a generic sense but even of the limitations that come with being human. And Pauline and Johannine theology agrees and indeed insists that the physical, fleshly body is important. Thus, 1 John begins with an affirmation that Jesus has been not only heard but also seen and touched (1 John 1:1), and the heart of Paul’s Christian hope is centered on the resurrection of the body (1 Cor 15). Moreover, if Christ is not human, then we are not saved; for “the unassumed is the unhealed.”

8.2.2. Adoptionism

At the other end of the spectrum is the group of views known broadly as adoptionism. Opposite of docetism, adoptionism affirms the full and complete humanity of Christ but then downgrades the divinity to a relation of special favor with God. Adoptionists differ among themselves with respect to just when the pivotal or significant moment of adoption occurs; some think that it happens at the baptism of Jesus, and others see it at the resurrection or perhaps even the ascension. But what they have in common is a Christology that denies that Jesus Christ is the eternal second person of the Trinity, the Son or Word who preexists his incarnate earthly career. Make no mistake: Jesus really is human. But according to this theory, he is not God in some sort of ontological (rather than merely honorific) sense. Again, this proposal offers an easy solution to the challenging problems of

Christology. But it is too easy; it solves the problem only by creating bigger problems. It was quite readily disposed of by arguments based on the biblical considerations that we have laid out here: Adoptionism cannot handle the New Testament witness to the preexistence of Christ, the works that Christ does as God while exercising divine attributes and prerogatives, Jesus's own claims to unity and equality with the Father, and, of course, the straightforward ascriptions of "Lord" and "God" to him.

We have already discussed the struggles with Arianism (in chapter 2), so we will only briefly recap our treatment of this theory here.³⁶ "Arianism" refers to the group of loosely related theories that emerged during the debates of the fourth^[338] and early fifth centuries. What they hold in common can be summarized in this way. First, God was not always Father but instead became the Father when he created the Son. Second, the Logos or Son is the creature who comes into existence from nothing as he is made by God (and that makes God the "Father"). Third, the Son is the creature that makes or creates everything else in existence. Fourth, the Son is—like all other creatures—necessarily and perpetually dependent upon God, for his is variable by nature rather than immutable. Fifth, this means that the Son is alien from the divine being and suffers from imperfect knowledge. Sixth, the Son then becomes incarnate to bring salvation to the world that he has created. This means that while the Son is in some sense "divine" and not merely human, nonetheless it is true that the Son is of a lesser or lower-ranked divinity; the Son is above all other creatures but below the ultimate God in honor, dignity, power, knowledge, and glory.³⁷

While it is relatively easy to dispatch the docetic and adoptionist proposals, the Arian theories are much more sophisticated and beguiling. But Arianism was resisted along several lines of argument. First, the biblical arguments that we have surveyed were important in the struggles with Arianism. For while Arianism can surely accommodate some of the biblical data about Christ (e.g., preexistence), there are other important points of data (e.g., the scriptural witness to the unity and equality of the Father and Son) that simply could not be reconciled with Arian thought. Moreover, as we have noted, Arianism struggles to account for the biblically based and widely practiced worship of Christ as well as the most basic Christian conviction that Christ is the Savior. Beyond this, Arianism is seen to be inconsistent with the doctrine of divine simplicity, for the levels or gradations of divinity that it posits are exactly what is ruled out by the doctrine of simplicity. Finally, and importantly, Arianism fails the test of monotheism, for taken one way it defaults to a unitarian doctrine of God and an adoptionist Christology, while taken the other way it collapses into outright polytheism. For if you have a higher or ultimate God and a lower-ranked creator deity who then becomes incarnate, you have at least two gods. And that, of course, is one god too many for monotheism.

8.2.3. Apollinarianism

Apollinarius was known as a staunch defender of pro-Nicene orthodoxy during the Arian debates of the fourth century. J. N. D. Kelly refers to him as "an enthusiast for the homoousion of the Son."³⁸ But even as he resisted the Arian downgrade of^[339] the divinity of Christ, he also (perhaps inadvertently) downgraded the full humanity of the incarnate Son. By all accounts, Apollinarianism understood the human mind and will to be necessarily sinful and thus essentially evil. By contrast, the divine Logos, precisely as divine, is immutable and necessarily good. So how could the human and the divine be combined in one person? The Apollinarian solution was neat and simple: The Logos becomes incarnate by taking upon himself a human body while replacing the human spirit and rational soul. As Reinhold Seeberg puts it, "The Logos assumed the body and soul of a man, but the divine Logos itself took the place of the spirit (*nous*) or intellectual soul (*psychē noera*)."³⁹ Christ is thus "the divine mind enfleshed in an animated body."⁴⁰ The immutable divine Logos thus empowers the human body, for by "having the divine life pulsing through him, the incarnate was made immune from psychic and fleshly passions,

and became not only himself invincible to death, but also able to destroy death.”⁴¹ Apollinarianism further insists that there is only one nature in Christ: “He is one nature (*mia physis*) since he is a simple, undivided Person (*prosōpon*), for the body is not a nature by itself, nor is the divinity in virtue of the incarnation a nature by itself.”⁴²

But this single nature is not—and cannot be—the same kind of human nature that everyone else has. For it is bereft of a human rational soul and will. Instead, it is a *tertium quid* (a third thing that is neither fully human nor completely divine).⁴³ As Joseph Tixeront puts it, Christ’s “humanity is not consubstantial with ours; between them, there is not *homoousia*, but *homoioōma* only.”⁴⁴ And it is at this point that the criticisms of Apollinarianism really ramp up: If the Son did not really become human—truly and authentically and fully human—then he did not come all the way to be one with us. If the will and rational soul are bypassed, then they are not redeemed. As Gregory of Nazianzus makes the point, “That which he ^[340]has not assumed he has not healed, but that which is united to his Godhead is also saved. If only half Adam fell, then that which Christ assumes and saves must be half also, but if the whole of his nature fell, it must be united to the whole nature of him that was begotten, and so be saved as a whole.”⁴⁵ Indeed, if the mind and will are necessarily sinful, then the human mind and will cannot be saved. And thus we are still dead in trespasses and sins. So if Apollinarianism is true, we have no hope of salvation.

8.2.4. Nestorianism

Nestorianism presents a very different type of challenge. By all accounts, Nestorius wanted to uphold the full divinity and the full humanity of Jesus Christ as the incarnate Son of God.⁴⁶ But he did so in a way that was seen to compromise the unity of the person. Nestorianism holds that “it is as foolish to suggest that Jesus can raise someone from the dead as it is to suggest that the Logos can ever die. The man Jesus of Nazareth dies on the cross, therefore, as a man subject to mortality like all other men. God the Word raised him from the dead as himself one who was beyond the power of death. The distinctive spheres and capacities of both . . . were always preserved.”⁴⁷ Interestingly, the controversy was sometimes centered on the proper way to refer to Mary. How should we think and talk about Mary? Just who is she? Is she, as Cyril of Alexandria and other opponents of Nestorianism insisted, rightly understood to be Theotokos? That is, is she the bearer or “Mother of God”? Or is she, as Nestorius thought, more properly understood to be Christotokos? In other words, is she merely the Mother of the humanity of Christ?

Nestorius was, to be sure, certain that Mary was the Mother of Jesus. That was not in dispute. So he can say that she is the Mother *of Christ*. But he considered it mistaken and problematic to say that she was the bearer *of God*, for, of course, God is eternal and immutable and cannot be in the womb of a woman. Cyril, on the other hand, insisted that a proper understanding of the unity of Christ entailed that Mary must be nothing less than Theotokos. For it is not merely the humanity of the Son in her womb; the miracle of the incarnation is that the Word who is the eternal Son of the Father entered our world in and through the womb of Mary. To ^[341]think otherwise and to take Nestorius’s side is to default to the conclusion that there are two persons, for the one in the womb of Mary is merely human. It is also to entail a form of adoptionism, for at some point (apparently safely outside Mary’s body) the divine Son unites to the humanity. Moreover, the Nestorian position relies upon a notion that the body of the woman was somehow unworthy of union with God, and against this view the orthodox account insisted that in no sense was God ashamed of the womb of Mary but instead was received into the hospitality of her body. Beth Felker Jones notes that while the Nestorian position “makes for a neat Christology, one that protects a piety that insists God must be beyond our troubles,” nonetheless it is “a heretical

Christology because it undoes the mercies of a God who is powerful enough to have no need of our protection and loving enough to cry, suffer, and die for our sake.”⁴⁸

8.2.5. Miaphysitism/Monothelitism

At the other end of the spectrum from Nestorianism is the group of theories roughly known as “Miaphysitism” or “monophysitism” (also sometimes called “Eutychianism” after one of the more prominent versions of it).⁴⁹ Harold O. J. Brown identifies the “fundamental impulse” of monophysitism as “the insistence that the unity of the divine and the human in Christ is fulfilled in the physical life of Christ and produces a single nature.”⁵⁰ John Meyendorff points out that for monophysitism, the terms *hypostasis*, “person,” and *physis*, “nature,” were synonymous.⁵¹ Accordingly, if the incarnate Son is one person, then the incarnate Son has one and only one nature. And just what is this single nature? It is not human nature. Nor is it the divine nature. Instead, as Iain Torrance explains, prominent monophysites “understood the Word incarnate as a *tertium quid*; not as the Word become man, but that the Word and a human nature had become some sort of ^[342]in-between thing, with peculiar properties of its own.”⁵² But if this is so, then, once again, we are left with the objection that what is unassumed is unhealed. Jones notes that the orthodox rejection of this view “is also the rejection of mistaken ideas that our salvation must basically destroy who we are. Not so. God’s saving work in our lives is with us, not against us. When God works to save us, he does not wipe away our humanity.”⁵³

A closely related issue concerns the number of wills in the incarnate Son. The monothelite proposals maintain that in the hypostatic union of humanity and divinity in Christ, we see nothing less than an ontological union of will. Their opponents, who eventually triumphed at the Sixth Ecumenical Council (680–681), insisted that affirmation of the full and complete humanity of Christ entails that **the human will of Christ remain intact and complete. So while the human will is always fully concordant with the divine will, nonetheless they remain distinct.** As Michael Pomazansky explains, the human will of Christ “was not changed into the divine will, and was not destroyed, but remained whole and operative. The Lord completely subjected it to the divine will, which in him is one with the will of the Father: ‘I have come down from heaven, not to do mine own will, but the will of him that sent me’ (John 6:38).”⁵⁴

8.3. The Chalcedonian Definition

A series of ecumenical councils offered careful and consideration evaluation of these various proposals. It is important to understand the purposes, limitations, and importance of these creeds.⁵⁵ They are not given as attempts at full explanations. But nor are they offered as just take-them-or-leave-them suggestions. Instead, they function as boundary statements and guidelines for the church. They reject erroneous and harmful positions, and they set limits to speculation. Within the boundaries outlined, they make a series of positive statements. So there are things that should be denied, and there are things that should be affirmed. But again, they do not serve as complete theological developments or even as summaries of all that should be said. Thus, there is ample room—between what should ^[343]be affirmed and what should be denied—for further theological development, exploration, and even speculation.

The most important of these conciliar statements is the Chalcedonian Definition (451). It states,

Therefore following the holy Fathers, we confess one and the same Lord Jesus Christ, and we teach harmoniously [that he is] the same perfect in Godhead, the same perfect in manhood, truly God and truly man, the same of a reasonable soul and body; consubstantial with the Father in Godhead, and the same consubstantial with us in manhood, like us in all things except sin; begotten before ages of the Father in Godhead, the same in the last days for us; and for our salvation [born] of Mary the virgin *theotokos* in manhood, one and the same Christ, Son, Lord, unique; acknowledged in two natures without confusion, without change, without division, without separation—the difference of the natures being in no means taken away because of the union, but rather the distinctive character of each nature being preserved, and [each] combining in one Person and hypostasis—not divided or separated into two Persons, but one and the same Son and only begotten God, Word, Lord Jesus Christ; as the prophets of old and the Lord Jesus Christ himself taught us about him, and the symbol of the Fathers has handed down to us.⁵⁶

With our discussion of the various controversies behind us, look closely at what the Chalcedonian statement is doing. The affirmations of Christ's full, complete, and perfect humanity and divinity are unmistakable: He is "truly God and truly man." All forms of adoptionism and Arianism are ruled out unequivocally by the statement that he is *homoousios* (consubstantial) with the Father, and all forms of docetism are rejected by the corresponding statement that he is *homoousios* (consubstantial) with us as well. Apollinarianism is forcefully denied by the affirmation that Christ's humanity includes "reasonable soul and body." Nestorianism is declared out of bounds by the affirmations that Christ is "one and the same Christ, Son, Lord" who was born of the Virgin Theotokos (Mother of God). Monophysitism is rejected by the affirmation of "two natures" and the corresponding insistence that "the difference of the natures being by no means taken away because of the union." The confession that the union of natures is "without confusion" disallows monophysitism; "without change" bars Apollinarianism, and "without division, without separation" rejects Nestorianism, as does the further [344] clarification that the one hypostasis or person is "not divided or separated into two persons."

As we have noted, it is important to understand that the conciliar formulations do not say all that rightly can or should be said about Jesus Christ. But it is also important to understand and appreciate the importance of what they do. For the fact that Jesus Christ is one person of two natures—both truly human and truly divine—is at the very heart of the gospel. Thomas F. Torrance makes this point with force:

If what Christ does, for example, in forgiving our sins, is not what God does, then it is not finally valid. If God himself has not come to be one with us in the incarnation, then the love of God finally falls short of coming all the way to be one with us, and is not ultimately love. If it was not God himself incarnate who suffered for us on the cross in making atonement, then the sacrifice of Christ has no ultimate and final validity, and we are still in our sins. If Jesus Christ and God are not of one and the same being, then we really do not know God, for he is some hidden inscrutable deity behind the back of Jesus, of whom we can only be terrified—and then the final judgment of the world will be a judgment apart from and without respect to Jesus Christ and his forgiving love and atoning sacrifice. Cut the bond in being between Jesus Christ and God, and the Gospel message becomes an empty mockery. But if Jesus Christ is of one and the same being as God, then all that Jesus said and did on our behalf, has staggering significance for us and the whole creation. But in this case it is essential to realize that Jesus Christ the Son of God is also man, of one and the same being and nature as we are. If he is not really man, then the great bridge which God has thrown across the gulf between himself and us, has no foundation on our side of the gulf. Jesus Christ, to be Mediator in the proper sense,

must be wholly and fully man as well as God. Hence the creed stresses the stark reality and actuality of his humanity.⁵⁷

These key elements of Christology—the full and robust humanity of Christ, the complete and undiminished divinity of Christ, and the unity of the one person who is Christ—are absolutely central to the good news of the Christian faith. God is for us. God is with us. Completely and unreservedly.

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8.4. The Fortunes and Future of Chalcedonian Christology

These are the key elements of an orthodox Christology. The conciliar formulations are very helpful in many ways, but they do not purport to say all that should be said (indeed, they say very little about the life, ministry, and teachings of Jesus) or pretend to answer all questions. Accordingly, Christian theologians have continued to plumb the depths of the doctrine of the incarnation. Sometimes the questions have arisen naturally, and sometimes they have come from critical pressure; for instance, both medieval Islamic theologians and modern philosophers have raised some important criticisms of the traditional doctrine that call for response and require Christian theologians to think more deeply about their faith.

What do we make of the claim that the one person who is Jesus Christ is both fully human and fully divine? According to Chalcedonian Christology, the natures remain intact and distinct in the unity of Christ's person. This raises many questions. What is the relation of the divine nature to the human nature? More specifically, we know that humans are creatures. And Christ is human. So is it right to say that Christ is a creature? Thomas Aquinas is one of many theologians who wrestle with such questions. He addresses head-on the question “whether what belongs to the human nature can be predicated of the divine nature.” While addressing objections, he cites the patristic theologian John of Damascus: “What is proper to the human nature cannot be said of the divine nature.” Aquinas explains further that “in the mystery of the incarnation the divine and human natures are not the same . . . hence what belongs to one nature cannot be predicated of the other if they are taken in the abstract,” and thus, for instance, we say that “the Son of God suffered but not that the divine nature suffered.”⁵⁸ So should we say that Christ is a creature? For Aquinas, the answer is yes—but it is a carefully qualified yes. He says that “we must not say absolutely that Christ is a creature or less than the Father; but with a qualification, namely, in his human nature.”⁵⁹ He offers further explanation: Some things, he says, are “observed to exist in a part” but “are not predicated of the whole simply, i.e., without qualification, for we do not say that the Ethiopian is white but that he is white as regards his teeth.” Similarly, when we say that Jesus Christ is subject to or subordinate to his Father, we must carefully qualify what is meant: “As we are not to understand that Christ is a creature simply, but only in his human nature^[346] . . . so also we are to understand that Christ is subject to the Father not simply but in his human nature.”⁶⁰

John of Damascus says that the human nature was deified by the union with the divine nature. But this does not mean that the human nature was changed into divinity or in any way ceased to be human. No, the humanity is always human nature—but it is now cleansed and purified so that human nature reaches its full potential and becomes all that it was meant to be. For, he says, “even after the union, both the natures abide unconfused and their properties unimpaired.” But “the flesh of the Lord received the riches of the divine energies through the purest union with the Word . . . without entailing the loss of any of its natural attributes.” He draws an analogy that will be used for centuries in later debates; like fire heats steel without the steel becoming the fire itself, so

also does the divinity radiate through the humanity of Christ. “For it is not in virtue of any energy of its own but through the Word united to it, that it manifests divine energy: for the flaming steel burns, not because it has been endowed in a physical way with burning energy, but because it has obtained this energy by its union with fire.”⁶¹

Within the bounds of commitment to creedal orthodoxy, there are further debates throughout late medieval and early modern scholasticism about the best way to think about the “communication of attributes” or “idioms” (*communicatio idiomatum*).⁶² There are intramural divisions among various schools of Roman Catholic thought, there are disputes between various Roman Catholic and Protestant theologians, and there are debates between Lutheran and Reformed theologians. For many theologians, it is best to simply predicate the attributes of the divine nature to the person and the attributes of the human nature to the person—but not predicate the properties of the divinity to the humanity and most certainly not to predicate the attributes of humanity to the divine nature. Other theologians judge it more appropriate to allow that the divine nature permeates the human nature in such a way that we can predicate divine properties (such as ubiquity or omnipresence) to the humanity. The former are concerned to avoid monophysitism; the latter are exercised to eliminate all vestiges of Nestorianism. But make no mistake: Theologians on all sides are committed to the creedal faith that they have inherited.

^[347] But other critics either demand truly radical revisions of the conciliar heritage or reject it entirely. Thus, the theologian Bruce L. McCormack asserts that “there exists at the heart of the Chalcedonian Definition a logical aporia, an unresolved contradiction.”⁶³ And the philosopher of religion John Hick claims that “to say, without further qualification, that the historical Jesus of Nazareth was also God is as devoid of meaning as to say that this circle drawn with a pencil on paper is also a square.”⁶⁴ Note the boldness and sweeping scope of Hick’s claim. He is not merely saying that the doctrine is mysterious or puzzling in some ways. He is not claiming that it suffers from lack of evidence. He is saying that it has the same logical status as the claim that a square is also a circle: He is saying that it is logically contradictory and incoherent—and thus necessarily false.

Is Hick correct? Is the core doctrine of orthodox Christianity really logically impossible and necessarily false? Some theologians think so, and they try to replace the conciliar faith with a more viable alternative. Some theologians (especially in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries) worked to develop kenotic Christologies. Taking a cue from Paul’s discussion of the kenosis or self-emptying of Christ, they suggest that the way to resolve the problem is to posit that the Son gave up or rejected whatever might be incompatible with true humanity. Some kenotic theorists are more extreme, and others are more modest; some make the truly radical proposal that what the Son emptied himself of was *divinity*, while others take more measured approaches and posit that what the Son surrendered or gave up were the omni- attributes that would be inconsistent with being genuinely human. So, on the more radical accounts, the Son was divine and then became human and thus was no longer divine, while on the more modest proposals, the Son remained divine but dropped off some of the divine attributes when he became human.⁶⁵

But such approaches have not proven attractive—and for good reason: They are deeply flawed. The notion that the incarnate Son is no longer divine—because now human—conflicts with the deep and broad biblical witness to the divinity ^[348] of the Son. If he is no longer divine, then he should not be accepting worship; he should not be claiming to perform divine actions or receive divine titles or be called “God.” If he is not really divine, then the great gulf that lies between Creator and creatures is still open—and, as Torrance has so eloquently put it, we are still in our sins and without hope. Or, if the Son is supposed to be somehow still divine but without having the full complement of divine attributes, then we run into many of the same problems. If the Son has a lesser divinity, then is he not a lower-ranked deity? Are there not two deities? And is not one of these deities below the other—in other words, is this not another version of the Arian heresy? And how is it even possible for the divine attributes to be divvied up like this? For if (any meaningful version of) the doctrine of divine simplicity is true, then it is not so much as logically possible for a being to have some divine attributes but not others.

But if such revisionist proposals are not successful, neither are they necessary. For the charge that the traditional, creedal doctrine is necessarily false has not been substantiated. Several important distinctions are important as we move forward.⁶⁶ The first is the distinction between *kind-essences* and *individual-essences*. An individual-essence (roughly equivalent to the medieval concept of *haecceitas*) is the set of properties that one must have to be a particular individual.⁶⁷ A kind-essence, on the other hand, is the full set of properties individually necessary and jointly sufficient for being a member of that natural kind. These attributes or properties are individually necessary; you must have them all to be a member of that kind. And they are jointly sufficient; if you have them all, then you just are a member of that kind. Understood in these terms, the fundamental Christian claim about Christ is not, of course, that he has two individual-essences. That truly would seem to be impossible. But the classical doctrine's teaching is that he has two kind-essences and one individual-essence. And while this is certainly unusual—the incarnation is, after all, utterly unique—it is not impossible.

The second relevant distinction is between *common* and *essential* human properties. It is easy to conflate these two categories, but it is important to avoid such confusion. An essential property is one that is part of the kind-essence humanity; it is one that must be possessed to be human. A common human property, on the ^[349]other hand, is a property that most or even all humans have. Now all essential properties are, of course, common, but it is not true that all common properties are essential. To illustrate this, Morris points out that the property of living on the surface of the earth is a common human property, but he denies that it is an essential property.⁶⁸ Even though it is so common as to be universal, it does not constitute what it means to be human—as if humans born on a lunar colony or in a space station would not be really human simply because they were born elsewhere. The third relevant distinction is being *merely human* and being *fully human*. To be fully human is simply to have the kind-essence humanity. But to be merely human is to have this kind-essence and no other. Of course, it is true that it is very *common* to have only one kind-essence; surely this is the default position for reality as we know it. Christians believe that the incarnation is utterly unique, after all. But from the mere fact that something is common—indeed very common—it does not follow that it is not possible for something to be otherwise.

As Morris points out, orthodox Christology says that Christ is *fully* human, but this does not mean that he must be *merely* human. For what makes him fully human is his possession of the kind-essence humanity, and the fact that the Son is more than human does not mean that he is nonhuman. And, of course, the Son is divine in virtue of having the kind-essence divinity. Armed with these distinctions, Morris argues that orthodox Christology should not be dismissed as incoherent, and he concludes that it is “logically above reproach.”⁶⁹

To say this much, however, leaves some important issues unaddressed. What, for instance, are we to make of Jesus's knowledge? He is human and thus would seem to be limited in knowledge; moreover, he confesses ignorance at various points (e.g., Mark 13:32). On the other hand, he is divine and thus (should be) omniscient. Morris himself offers a “two-minds” proposal, according to which the human mind of Jesus knows basically whatever a first-century Jewish man would have known while the divine mind is omniscient. He posits an “asymmetric accessing relation” between the two minds; the divine mind (as omniscient) has unlimited and uninterrupted access to the human mind, but the human mind has access to the divine mind only on stated occasions when the divine mind gives it access.⁷⁰ This offers an explanation for why Jesus sometimes confesses ignorance and at other points foretells the future and knows the thoughts and intentions of other people.

But Morris's proposals do not satisfy everyone (many think that it is too close to Nestorianism). Some appreciate the important distinctions but then opt for ^[350]a modified kenotic account.⁷¹ This is not to be confused with the older kenotic alternatives to Chalcedon; rather, the proponents offer it as a thoroughly orthodox account. The idea is not that the Son surrenders part or even all his divinity. Instead, it is that the Son, in taking upon himself the “form of a slave” (Phil 2:7), gives up or “empties himself” of the common employment of the essential divine attributes. So, on this account, the Son is fully *homoousios* with the Father and the Spirit; he has

the same divine attributes. However, the modified kenotic approach demands that we rethink our way through the divine attributes, and, in light of the incarnation, we come to conclude that the Son is omniscient-unless-kenotically-and-redemptively incarnate. The Father and Holy Spirit have the same attribute, but they employ it differently (precisely because they are not incarnate). So what the Son surrenders is the common usage of the essential divine attributes, and the proponents of the modified kenotic approach defend the theory as not only consistent with Chalcedon but also as congruent with the New Testament depictions of Jesus and as spiritually rich and powerful.

Many Christians, however, adhere more closely to traditional scholastic formulations of the doctrine. Marilyn McCord Adams defends the older scholastic approaches in holding that the person of the Son took upon himself a particular concrete human nature, in other words, a particular body-soul composite. Accordingly, some things are to be said of God according to his humanity, and others are to be said of him according to his divinity.⁷² Eleonore Stump, closely following medieval strategies, says that “the fact that both limited and unlimited power are attributed to Christ does not show the Chalcedonian Definition of the incarnation to be incoherent, because omnipotence is predicated of Christ in his divine nature and lack of omnipotence is predicated of him in his human nature”—thus “Christ qua God is omnipotent; qua human, he is not.”⁷³

Stump understands that such a strategy, however popular in the tradition, is unpopular today because it is seen to offer a merely semantic solution that leaves the real problem intact.⁷⁴ But she argues that the view is defensible nonetheless (given a proper understanding of parts, wholes, and their properties). On Aquinas’s view, as she explains it, “There is a distinction between a property a ^[351]whole has in its own right and a property that it has in virtue of having a constituent that has that property in its own right,” and “a whole can borrow a property from one of its constituents.” Drawing on the molecule CAT/enhancer-binding protein (C/EBP) as an analogy, she argues that we can see this clearly. C/EBP “is a dimer, each of whose subunits is a protein which is coiled in an alpha helix coil. The molecule thus has the property of being coiled in the alpha helix manner, but it has that property in virtue of the fact that it has two parts which are coiled in that way. Each of these parts of the molecule, however, is coiled in the alpha helix manner in its own right. On the other hand, the whole molecule has the property of regulating DNA transcription, and this property it has in its own right.” At the same time, C/EBP is a “conglomerate of two such dimer units which bend away from each other in a limp Y-shape at one end of the molecule.” What this yields is the conclusion that while it is true that C/EBP “‘qua dimer with coiled subunits has the property of being coiled in the alpha helix manner’ predicates a property of the whole molecule which it borrows from a part” (a part that has it in its own right), it is also true that C/EBP “qua Y-shaped is not coiled in the alpha helix manner.”⁷⁵ Analogously, the incarnate Son has some properties qua human nature and has other properties qua divine nature. Stump thus concludes that, when suitably understood, this model serves to remove the threat of contradiction from the orthodox doctrine.⁷⁶

So where does this leave us? It leaves us with several approaches that can claim continuity with Scripture and the creedal tradition. Which approach is preferable will depend on a range of factors that each require further judgments (both theological and philosophical). Some philosophers even suggest that the doctrine of the incarnation is one of the very rare places (perhaps the only such place) where a contradiction is logically acceptable.⁷⁷ As we have seen, some approaches reconceive of the divine nature so that there is no contradiction (e.g., the modified kenotic theory). Others approaches, as we have also seen, are committed to the defense of more strictly traditional doctrines, and they argue that, when properly understood, the classical doctrine is not contradictory. The “qua” move may be vulnerable to the criticism that it offers a merely semantic response to a deeper metaphysical problem; some critics worry that it has the “appearance of verbal ^[352]chicanery.”⁷⁸ But even if simplistic appeal to the qua move is problematic, the basic insight defended by the qua strategy indeed is defensible. And thus, as Timothy Pawl concludes, “Christ is said to be passible in exactly the same way that you are: you and Christ both have natures that are causally affectable. And he is said to be impassible in exactly the

same way that the Father is: they both have a nature that is not causally affectable. Those two predicates would imply a contradiction were they both said of you (owing to the fact that you have but a single nature).”⁷⁹ But the incarnate Christ, of course, is different in precisely the most relevant way: He is one person in two natures. Thus, contradiction is avoided.⁸⁰

8.5. The Life and Ministry of Our Lord

Jon Sobrino is representative of those theologians who worry that focus on the traditional christological formulas and debates has the tendency to reduce Christ to a “sublime abstraction.” Sobrino says that “it has been possible for Christians, in the name of Christ, to ignore or even contradict fundamental principles and values that were preached and acted on by Jesus of Nazareth.” Pointing not only to the difficulties but also to the limitations of the Chalcedonian Definition, he suggests instead that our starting point should be “the historical Jesus”; that is, we should focus on “the person, teaching, attitudes, and deeds of Jesus of Nazareth.”⁸¹ We agree with Sobrino that the actual life and ministry of Jesus really matter, and we now turn to consideration of several crucially important moments. We do so, however, largely under the rubric provided by the Apostles’ and Niceno-Constantinopolitan Creeds.⁸²

8.5.1. “Conceived by the Holy Spirit, Born of the Virgin Mary”

The creeds affirm that Jesus Christ was born as the child of Mary the Holy Virgin. The doctrine of the virgin birth maintains that the eternal Son of God, who ^[353]is eternally begotten of the Father, became incarnate in the womb of Mary via supernatural means. The doctrine is held with unanimity in historic Christianity, and it continues to be affirmed by orthodox Christians. The doctrine does not claim that Mary’s body was a kind of holding tank and conduit for an already fully formed male zygote—as if Mary makes no contribution other than the rental of her womb. Nor, of course, does the traditional doctrine claim that the Holy Spirit is a male who impregnates Mary. Oliver D. Crisp summarizes the central claim of the doctrine: “As the God Bearer, [Mary] is the one whose gamete is miraculously fertilized by the action of the Holy Spirit so that her womb may bear God Incarnate,” and where the normal process would be for “the Y chromosome necessary for the act of syngamy by which the fused male and female gametes produce a male zygote” to be supplied by a human male, in the case of Christ “the genetic material that would normally be supplied by a male gamete was miraculously introduced to the ovum of the Virgin.”⁸³ This doctrine is affirmed in the creeds; it should be considered settled dogma. It also raises questions about the identity and role of Mary.

Mary is the Mother of our Lord. But just who is she? She is adored by some devout believers; but she is virtually ignored by many others. It is an understatement to say that she has been the subject of considerable controversy in Christian theology. Jaroslav Pelikan documents how Mary has been viewed in both theology and popular piety (as expressed in art and poetry) throughout Christian history. For instance, she is the second Eve who not only guarantees the true humanity of Jesus but also by her faith and obedience reverses the doubt and disobedience of Eve. She is Theotokos, the “God-bearer” or “Mother of God.” She is the model of chastity. She is the Mediatrix who is Christ’s cosufferer, the one who now intercedes for the saints to Christ. She is the model of faith in God’s word. She is the conquering Queen of Heaven.⁸⁴ In some (though certainly not all) expressions of contemporary Roman Catholic piety, Mary is elevated to a place of preeminence and seems to be the focus of

spiritual formation. For instance, in the Parroquia La Virgen Milagrosa (a massive cathedral in Lima, Peru), a statue of Mary is front and center in the central nave, with statues of angels bowing beneath her. This enormous statue is elevated to the highest point in the cathedral, and it is brilliantly illumined by backlighting and by a bright crown of stars above her head. Far below ^[354] the Ave Maria sign that sits beneath the statue, there is a very small crucifix. It is impossible to miss the focus: Attention is centered precisely on *Mary*; this is all about *her*. On the other hand, in much popular evangelical piety, Mary is virtually invisible. As Beverly Roberts Gaventa notes, “For most Protestants, Mary is little more than a character in the Christmas story.”⁸⁵ Mary is, at most, a silent character in Christmas pageants or live nativity scenes, and she has one job: to look cute. In some cases, Protestants have been overtly and aggressively anti-Marian. Timothy George recites the oft-repeated story of a time when the Scottish Reformer John Knox was a prisoner on a French ship: “The Catholic chaplain of Knox’s ship held forth a beautifully painted wooden statue of the Blessed Virgin Mary and encouraged Knox . . . to show proper reverence,” but “when the statue of Mary was forcibly placed in Knox’s hand, he grabbed it and immediately threw it overboard into the sea” while saying, “Let our Lady now save herself!”⁸⁶

But such extreme and polarized views are not the only options. Thankfully, we can, on the one hand, eliminate certain theories and, on the other hand, make positive affirmations (while also admitting that there is a proper place for theological modesty with respect to several issues).

Some doctrinal proposals about Mary not only go beyond biblical teaching and lack theological warrant but indeed go *against* the plain teaching of Scripture and the implications of creedal orthodoxy. For instance, Leonardo Boff promotes what Tim Perry and Daniel Kendall refer to as “a very high Mariology in which immaculate conception, virginal maternity, and bodily assumption are supplemented with very strong notions of co-redemption and co-mediation.”⁸⁷ Boff claims that “the Virgin Mary, Mother of God and of all men and women, realizes the feminine absolutely and eschatologically, inasmuch as the Holy Spirit has made her his temple, sanctuary, and tabernacle in so real and genuine a way that she is to be regarded as hypostatically united to the Third Person of the Blessed Trinity.”⁸⁸ By making her the “incarnation of the Holy Spirit,” Boff’s “Mary is Christ’s equal.”⁸⁹ But Christ has no equal! Christ, and Christ alone, is “the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation; for in him all things in heaven and on earth were created, things ^[355] visible and invisible, whether thrones or dominions or rulers or powers—all things have been created through him and for him. He himself is before all things, and in him all things hold together” (Col 1:15–17). Christ—and Christ alone—has “first place in everything” (Col 1:18). Nor does Christ need a coredeemer or another mediator. To the contrary, the “one mediator between God and humankind” is “Christ Jesus, himself human, who gave himself a ransom for all” (1 Tim 2:5–6). It is through Christ that “God was pleased to reconcile to himself all things, whether on earth or in heaven, by making peace through the blood of his cross” (Col 1:20). Jesus Christ is the one who suffers and dies. Jesus Christ is the one resurrected; the one who ascends to the right hand of the Father, the one who is the “priest forever” (Heb 7:17), the one who “always lives to make intercession” (Heb 7:25). He is “the Alpha and the Omega” (Rev 1:8). He is the “pioneer and perfecter of our faith” (Heb 12:2). Simply put, *Jesus Christ* is the Redeemer and Mediator. Thus, we have no option but to judge views such as that of Boff to be deeply mistaken.

Other Marian doctrines are more debatable. For instance, many theologians—including important Protestants—have not hesitated to affirm the perpetual virginity of Christ.⁹⁰ Many theologians in the tradition have believed in the immaculate conception of Mary (this Marian theory became official Roman Catholic dogma in 1854). But major theologians—including no less than Thomas Aquinas—resist this notion.⁹¹ Others hold to the bodily assumption of Mary into heaven (a dogma that was not made official until 1950).⁹² Some of these postulates about Mary should be judged to go beyond biblical teaching but not necessarily against it. For instance, the doctrine of the bodily assumption of Mary seems to us to violate no theological principles that are confirmed as orthodox or are otherwise important. At the same time, however, it must be said that the doctrine of Mary’s bodily assumption lacks unambiguous biblical warrant or other theological demonstration.⁹³ Thus, the

positive case for this doctrine seems inconclusive.⁹⁴ And so, while there are no in-principle theological objections or compelling bib^[356]lical counterarguments to it, the thesis must be considered unproven. Such proposals may warrant further consideration, and such consideration should be done with modesty and humility.

More importantly, we also make several positive affirmations about Mary, and we hold these to be important. First, as we have already noted (in our discussion of Nestorianism), creedal orthodoxy judges Mary to be the “Mother of God” or “God-bearer” (Theotokos). Such a striking claim must, of course, be properly understood. It does not mean that Mary gave birth to the Trinity. Nor does it mean that divinity began to exist in her womb. Nor yet does it mean that the second person of the Trinity came into existence in Mary’s body. John of Damascus explains,

For inasmuch as he who was born was true God, she who bore the true God incarnate is the Mother of God. For we hold that God was born of her, not implying that the divinity of the Word received from her the beginning of its being, but meaning that God the Word himself, who was begotten of the Father timelessly before the ages, and was with the Father and the Spirit without beginning and through eternity, took up his abode in these last days for the sake of our salvation in the Virgin’s womb, and was without change made flesh and born of her. For the holy Virgin did not bear mere man but true God, and not mere God but God incarnate.⁹⁵

Conciliar clarification is helpful: “We do not, however, say that the Virgin Mary gave birth to the unity of this Trinity, but only to the Son who alone assumed our nature.”⁹⁶ But with proper understanding and qualification, we should not shrink from this fundamental affirmation. Even Karl Barth, who was so concerned to avoid the various excesses that he referred to “Mariology” as “an excrescence, i.e., a diseased construct of theological thought,” said of Theotokos that “we affirm and approve it as a legitimate expression of Christological truth” and said that it was not only “sensible and permissible” but also “necessary as an auxiliary Christological proposition.”⁹⁷ Beyond mere affirmation, we should marvel at the truth expressed by the statement. As Martin Luther exclaims, “Mary suckled God, rocked God to sleep, prepared broth and soup for God.”⁹⁸ Thus, it is “with justice^[357] and truth that we call the holy Mary the Mother of God.”⁹⁹ Amy Peeler’s summary is insightful: “In the incarnation, God has deemed the female body—the [ceremonially] impure, bleeding female body—worthy to handle the most sacred of all things, the very body of God.”¹⁰⁰

Second, Mary is a preeminent model for Christians as we seek to learn how to be obedient to the word of God and faithful to Christ. As Luther puts it, she is “our dear professor and teacher (*unsere liebe Meisterin und Lehrerin*).”¹⁰¹ At one level, she is an exemplar of both the solidarity of God with the poor and of God’s people with the poor (Luke 1:51–53).¹⁰² That is to say, it is significant both that she identifies with the poor and that God comes to her and works in and through her as one who is without privilege, power, or prestige. Mary is an exemplar and model in other ways as well. She is a model of humility, courage, and faithfulness. Her marvelous Magnificat is, in the words of David S. Yeago, “the prototype of the church’s faith and prophecy,” and therefore she is “the archsinger of the praise of God’s mercy in Christ.”¹⁰³

Third, Mary is the new Eve. Patristic theologians make much of the parallels and contrasts between Eve and Mary: Eve listens to temptation and is led to doubt and then to sin, and Mary responds in faith to a startling word and then bears the Word within her; Eve’s doubt and sin lead to death and destruction, and Mary’s faith and obedience lead to life and peace.¹⁰⁴ The importance of Mary’s *consent* can hardly be overstated: “Here am I, the servant of the Lord; let it be with me according to your word” (Luke 1:38). Her consent is, of course, in response to divine initiative. But it is vitally important nonetheless.¹⁰⁵ When the angelic announce^[358]ment comes to her,

Mary does not know how any of this will work out. Nor does she receive anything in the way of a fulsome or detailed explanation when she asks. But she “*consents* to God’s redemptive design, and to her vocation within that design.”¹⁰⁶ Thus, Mary’s agency is respected, and her agency is included in the drama of salvation.¹⁰⁷ As Yeago observes, this means that Mary is not only “prototype and model” but also “an *active agent* of the formation of the church and the believer.”¹⁰⁸

Finally, Mary may be seen as a model and exemplar of complete or entire sanctification. Her consent is an act of consecration, and it is one that is full and complete. As Yeago says, “Her bodily ‘motherhood’ is constituted in the covenant-exchange of divine word and answering faith, a faith that involves a ‘total gift of self,’ and, therefore, in Pauline terms, the presentation *also of her body* as a ‘living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God’ (Rom 12:1).”¹⁰⁹ There is some debate in the tradition about when she is completely sanctified, but there should be no question that she is pure; she is, after all, the *Holy* and Blessed Virgin Mary.

8.5.2. “Suffered Under Pontius Pilate, Was Crucified, Died, and Was Buried”

This affirmation speaks plainly of the central fact of the Gospels: that Christ genuinely suffered, really died, and actually was buried in a tomb. Moreover, it explains his death as a locatable historical event: It was during the jurisdiction of Pontius Pilate. Furthermore, it underscores the heinous nature of the death. As Alister E. McGrath explains, crucifixion was “the most barbaric form of execution known, ideally suited as a deterrent.” Crucifixion was, by all accounts, an instrument of torture that was as humiliating as it was excruciating. Thus, McGrath says that “to say that Jesus died, or just that he was executed, misses the barbarism of the way in which he died,” for “the full sadism of human nature was brought to bear on him” as he died a “shameful and degrading death.”¹¹⁰

We are certain that the death involved physical suffering that is difficult to imagine, and there can be little doubt that it produced great mental and emotional stress as well. Beyond these affirmations, however, theologians sometimes^[359] disagree about the nature and extent of Christ’s sufferings. Consider Christ’s cry of dereliction from the cross: “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” (Matt 27:46; Mark 15:34). What does this mean?¹¹¹

Some theologians interpret Christ’s cry to signal nothing less than the utter alienation of the Son from the Father. Thus, Jürgen Moltmann says that there is “enmity between God and God” that is “to the highest degree.” Thus, the “suffering in the passion of Christ is abandonment, rejection by God, his Father.” The Trinity is thus ruptured or broken, and nothing less will account for the sufferings of Christ in the passion. This “revolution in the concept of God” is demanded by the crucifixion.¹¹²

Similarly, some theologians insist that Christ is considered odious to God and indeed is damned by God due to the fact that the sins of humans are legally accounted or imputed to Christ. Thus, **the Reformed scholastic theologian Wilhelmus à Brakel insists that “Christ did indeed suffer eternal damnation”**; he is sure not only that Christ has suffered “total separation from God in the total manifestation of divine wrath” but indeed that Christ suffered this “to the fullest extent.”¹¹³ More recently, R. C. Sproul states that “the Father imputed to him every sin of every one of his people, the most intense, dense concentration of evil” and the “ultimate obscenity.” Since “God is too holy to look upon sin,” the Father “could not bear to look at that concentrated monumental condensation of evil, so he averted his eyes from his Son” and “the light of his countenance was turned off.” The sufferings of Christ, then, culminate in the complete abandonment and rejection of the Son by the Father, for “God cursed him. . . . It was if there was a cry from heaven, as if Jesus heard the words, ‘God damn you.’”¹¹⁴

But many theologians in the tradition take a radically different position. They explicitly and forcefully deny that Christ’s cry from the cross signals any kind of relational distance—much less antipathy or hostility—between the Father and the Son. John of Damascus is both clear and emphatic: “Neither as God nor as man was

^[360] he ever forsaken by the Father, nor did he become sin or a curse.”¹¹⁵ Similarly, Peter Lombard says that we should simply say that “God abandoned that man to death in some way, because for a time he exposed him to the power of his persecutors”; in other words, “God did not defend him by displaying his power so that he would not die.”¹¹⁶ Thomas Aquinas is even more explicit: Yes, God forsakes Christ “by not shielding him from the passion but abandoning him to his persecutors,” but at the same time, Christ retains the beatific vision throughout the passion.¹¹⁷

Still other theologians find themselves somewhere between these two extremes. They reject the conclusion that the Father cursed and damned the Son, and they find abhorrent the notion that the Trinity was broken. On the other hand, however, they do not find adequate support for the conclusion that Christ enjoys the beatific vision throughout the passion. Instead, they conclude that while Christ was not actually abandoned or rejected or hated or cursed by his Father, due to his identification with human sinners he experiences intense feelings of abandonment and separation. Thus, John Calvin denies genuine strife within the Trinity: “We do not . . . insinuate that God was ever hostile to him or angry with him,” for “how could he be angry with his beloved Son, with whom he was well pleased?”¹¹⁸ Similarly, the Reformed scholastic theologian Francis Turretin says that what Christ experienced was a “withdrawal of vision” but not “a dissolution of union” with his Father.¹¹⁹ More recently Eleonore Stump suggests that, given the omniscience of Christ’s divine nature that is accessible to Christ’s human nature, it is possible that “in his human nature, Christ can mind-read in ways not possible for mere human persons.”¹²⁰ Accordingly, “the human psyche of the person of Christ is opened on the cross to the psyches of all human beings,” and “every vile, shocking, disgusting, repulsive psychic state accompanying every human evil act will be at once, miraculously, in the human psyche of Christ.”¹²¹ Thus, Christ is perfectly sinless and altogether pure, but he bears within himself the sins of the whole world and fully knows the weight of them. So while he is never separated ^[361] from the Father, his identification with human sinners causes him to share their experiences of abandonment and alienation.

Let us take stock of the situation. With this range of perspectives in mind, we conclude that there are very good theological reasons to hold the “broken Trinity” theories at arm’s length.¹²² Nowhere does the Bible say that the Father rejected or hated or cursed the Son. To the contrary, Jesus’s statement itself is a direct echo of a psalm that tells us that God “did not despise or abhor the affliction of the afflicted; he did not hide his face from me, but heard when I cried to him” (Ps 22:24). Moreover, the last words of Christ from the cross are expressions of filial love and trust (e.g., Luke 23:46) and a shout of triumph (John 19:30). And, in broader theological perspective, a ruptured Trinity is not so much as even possible—to say that the Trinity is broken is to say that the God of the Christian faith does not exist.

8.5.3. “Descended into Hell”

This affirmation, found in the Apostles’ Creed but not the Niceno-Constantinopolitan Creed, is one of the more controversial of the credal statements. What does it mean? Thomas C. Oden notes that there is a “healthy variety of traditional interpretations,” and his summary suggests that there are four main theories: the descent as simply death, the descent as “empathic suffering,” the descent as the announcement of “victory over sin and death,” and descent as the proclamation of the good news.¹²³ In the first group, some theologians understand the claim to be nothing more than a reinforcement of the prior statement that Jesus really died. As McGrath puts it, “It is a statement of the belief that Jesus *really did die*.”¹²⁴ “Hell” here is then understood as “the place of the dead” (Sheol, Hades), and the central point is antidocetic. Other theologians understand it quite differently. Sometimes closely tracking with the “broken Trinity” view discussed earlier, some take it to mean that Christ is sentenced to the torments of hell to suffer for sin. Still others interpret the claim in light of Peter’s statement that Christ “went

and made a proclamation to the spirits in prison, who in former times did not obey” (1 Pet 3:19). They posit that between Christ’s death and resurrection, he went into hell (understood either as the place of separation from God or simply as the realm of the dead) and proclaimed the good news of his victory to the saints who had died under the old covenant and who had been awaiting redemption.¹²⁵ A re^[362]lated theory suggests that Christ proclaims the good news to those sinners who had died under the old covenant and who were only now able to hear the gospel offer of salvation. Still other theologians, sometimes noting that the statement is found only in the Apostles’ Creed and not in any ecumenical creed, reject the claim entirely; one concludes that “there would be all gain and no loss if it were dropped from the Creed once and for all.”¹²⁶

We are left with some ambiguity surrounding the claim itself. Clearly, if we take the creedal statement to refer only to the fact of Christ’s physical death and burial, then we should not hesitate to affirm it. We find the view that Christ released the saints who had died under the old covenant attractive even if unproven. If it means more than that, then we should also admit that we are left with some uncertainty about the theological warrant for the claim; accordingly, the issue deserves more theological analysis and, in any case, calls for theological humility.

8.5.4. “On the Third Day He Rose Again from the Dead”

The theological meaning of the resurrection is considered in more detail later, but at this point it is important to make the following observations.¹²⁷ First, as Gerald O’Collins observes, there is great “revelatory significance” in Christ’s resurrection. It has deep meaning and fosters great hope for all those who are joined in union with Christ (e.g., 1 Thess 1:10; 4:13; 1 Cor 15:1–58). Beyond this, it also reveals truths that help us understand “not only the believers’ new life of grace here and now (e.g., Rom 4:23–25; 8:9–17) but also the future of Israel (Rom 9–11) and indeed of the whole world (Rom 8:18–25).” The resurrection is a vindication of the ministry and life of Jesus. It is an expression of the power and love of God for the world and indeed for sinners. And, as O’Collins says, “Easter showed that God had already initiated the resurrection of human beings and their world (Rom 8:29; 1 Cor 15:20, 23; Col 1:18)”; for in “raising and transforming Jesus in his human existence, God was seen to have begun the work of finally transforming the rest of creation and the rest of history.”¹²⁸ Second, note that the creedal affirmations tie the death and resurrection of Christ together. Salvation is found in neither the death of Christ taken in isolation nor only in the resurrection as the defeat of death. More will be said about these matters shortly (in the following chapter on the work of Christ),^[363] but at this point it is important to understand that the work of Christ—which indeed is the undivided work of the triune God—should be understood holistically. The resurrection is redemptive as well as revelatory.¹²⁹

8.5.5. “He Ascended into Heaven”

Oden observes that the “ascension begins on earth and ends in heaven.”¹³⁰ The doctrines of the ascension, session, and second coming are examined in detail later; at this point we highlight the following observations. It is important to understand that Christ is raised bodily. He does not drop his flesh on the way up—as if it were somehow beneath him to remain incarnate or as if the body was too sullied for heaven. The ascension is a *bodily* ascension, and the return of Christ will be a *bodily* return. The fact that the Son remains incarnate and retains his body is of great pastoral comfort to the people of God. The Heidelberg Catechism enumerates the benefits: “First, that he is our Advocate in the presence of his Father in heaven. Second, that we have our flesh in heaven as a sure

pledge that he, as the Head, will also take us, his members, up to himself. Third, that he sends to us his Spirit as a counterpledge by whose power we seek what is above, where Christ is, sitting at the right hand of God, and not things that are on earth.”¹³¹ And as the ascension begins on earth and ends in heaven, so also his session or reign is “at the right hand of the Majesty on high” (Heb 1:3; 12:2; 1 Pet 3:22). Speaking of the “immeasurable greatness” of God’s power, Saint Paul tells us that “God put this power to work in Christ when he raised him from the dead and seated him at his right hand in the heavenly places, far above all rule and authority and power and dominion, and above every name that is named, not only in this age but also in the age to come. And he has put all things under his feet and has made him the head over all things for the church, which is his body, the fullness of him who fills all in all” (Eph 1:20–23). And his triumphant return will begin in heaven and end on earth.

The Son's Saving Work

In the last chapter, we focused our attention primarily on the doctrine of the incarnation or the person of Christ. We began by identifying Jesus Christ as the one who was born of the Virgin Mary, who was crucified under Pontius Pilate, who suffered death and was buried, who rose again on the third day, and who will come again in glory to judge the living and the dead. Shifting our focus from the Apostles' and Nicene Creeds, we then explored a series of proposals for understanding the relationship between Christ's divine and human natures, culminating with the Chalcedonian Definition.

Now that we understand who Jesus is, we must turn our attention to the question, Why the incarnation? Why did the eternally begotten Word take on flesh and dwell among us? And what did he accomplish in doing so? In posing and answering these questions, we will find ourselves at the very heart of the Christian gospel. We will also find ourselves contemplating the central object and mystery of the Christian faith, namely, the God who has acted decisively on our behalf in the incarnation, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

9.1. The Goodness of God and the Salvation of the World

Perhaps the best way to begin getting at the motive or purpose of the incarnation is to recall what we have now said repeatedly concerning God and creation, namely, that God is necessarily loving and good and that a necessarily loving and good God can be the source of only a good and beautiful creation. But the moment we say this, we look around us and see a created order that is coming apart at the seams. Everywhere we turn, violence and destruction are the order of the day. Nations are rising against nations, and we are even destroying the earth itself through selfishness and benign neglect. Instead of displaying the glory of God, creation is groaning (Rom 8:22). It seems to be on the verge of death.

^[365]None of this is new. Violence, disorder, and chaos have been the order of the day almost from the beginning. Thus, we do not make it more than a few pages into the book of Genesis before Adam and Eve are being expelled from the garden of Eden for their disobedience. If that wasn't bad enough, we discover just a few pages later that Cain has killed his brother Abel. In both accounts of the origins of sin, our violence and disobedience do not go unnoticed. To Eve, God asks, "What is this that you have done?" (Gen 3:13). And to

Cain, God declares, “What have you done? Listen; your brother’s blood is crying out to me from the ground” (Gen 4:10).

Unfortunately, these original sins are not one-time or isolated events. They set into motion a pattern of sin and death that persists across space and time. Thus, at the outset of his classic work, *On the Incarnation*, Athanasius writes,

In their transgressions, human beings had not stopped short of any defined limits, but gradually pressing forward they had passed beyond all measure: from the beginning they were inventors of evil and called death and corruption upon themselves; while later, turning to vice and exceeding all lawlessness, not stopping at one evil but continuing in time every new evil, they became insatiable in sinning. For there were adulterers and thefts everywhere, the whole earth was full of murders and plundering. There was no concern for law regarding corruption and vice; every wickedness, individually and jointly, was being carried out by all. Cities warred against cities, and nations rose up against nations; the whole world was torn apart by factions and battles, everyone competing in lawlessness.¹

It is important to see what is happening here. The situation is exactly the opposite of what God intended. God created the world out of the abundance of his goodness and love. And he did so to display his goodness and love for the enjoyment of creatures—so that we might worship and enjoy him forever. And God did all this, only for human beings to turn away from their Creator, to turn against one another, and even to turn against creation itself. The real question then is this: What should God do?

At first glance, the answer to this question is straightforward. God himself declared death to be the penalty for disobedience, a fact later recalled by the apostle Paul when he says, “The wages of sin is death” (Rom 6:23). At one level, then, it is simply a matter of God keeping his word. Athanasius himself says that it would be absurd if God, being truthful, did not hand us over to death as the consequence^[366] of our sin. He goes on to say that death is a fitting consequence for sin, as it prevents our sin and destructiveness from continuing unabated. We might sin for a season or even a lifetime, but sooner or later, even the worst instances of sinning must come to an end when we die. Death sets a limit to what even the wealthiest and most powerful and destructive sinners (e.g., totalitarian dictators) can do.

But while death may be a just consequence for sin, it cannot have the last word. At best, it is a stopgap measure, but it is not a fitting end given God’s goodness. Why not? Athanasius declares,

It was not worthy of the goodness of God that those created by him should be corrupted through the deceit wrought by the devil upon human beings. And it was supremely improper that the workmanship of God in human beings should disappear either through their own negligence or through the deceit of demons. . . . The weakness, rather than the goodness, of God, is made known by neglect, if, after creating, he abandoned his own work to be corrupted, rather than if he had not created the human being in the beginning. For not making him, there would have been no one considering the weakness, but once he made him and created him out of nothing, it was most absurd that his works should be destroyed and especially before the sight of the maker.²

This is the dilemma that Athanasius poses at the beginning of *On the Incarnation*. Of course, his entire point is that it is only a rhetorical dilemma. Given God’s nature as necessarily good, the notion that God would allow

human beings permanently to foil his purposes by destroying his good creation is virtually unthinkable. To help us see this more clearly, Athanasius goes on to develop and deploy the following analogy for the incarnation of the Word:

Truly [the incarnation] supremely befitted the goodness of God. For if a king constructed a house or a city, and it is attacked by bandits because of the carelessness of its inhabitants, he in no way abandons it, but avenges and saves it as his own work, having regard not for the carelessness of the inhabitants but for his own honor. All the more so, the Word of the all-good Father did not neglect the race of human beings, created by himself, which was going to corruption, but he blotted out the death which had occurred through the offering of his own body, and correcting their carelessness by his own teaching, restoring *every aspect* of human beings *by his own power*.³

^[367]A fourth-century theologian from Alexandria, Athanasius is not alone in viewing the matter this way. For example, many centuries later in the Latin West, Saint Anselm of Canterbury will answer the question—Why did God become human?—this way: “Surely there seems a sufficiently cogent reason why God had a need to do the things of which we are speaking: the human race, clearly his most precious piece of workmanship, had been completely ruined; it was not fitting that what God had planned for mankind should be utterly nullified, and the plan in question could not be brought into effect unless the human race were set free by its Creator *in person*.”⁴

In these excerpts from the classical Christian tradition, we can discern three basic principles. First, the God who creates all that is—all things visible and invisible—deeply values the works of his hands, so much so that it is not in his nature to abandon them to corruption and ruin. We see this principle in Scripture when God swears by himself to fulfill the covenant that he makes with Abraham. The God of Christianity is not a fickle deity. On the contrary, he is faithful to himself and to his purposes. He will finish what he has begun.

Second, when things go awry—when the works of his hands are threatened by corruption and death—he takes it upon himself to correct, to save, and to heal. He redeems, restores, and renews “by his own power.” He fulfills his good purposes for creation “in person.” The God of Christianity is not a distant or disinterested deity. On the contrary, in the incarnation, he comes to our rescue himself. He is personally and directly involved in the redemption of his good and beautiful creation.

Third, in coming to our rescue himself, God is fulfilling the entirety of his plan for creation and for human beings. There simply are no half measures in the salvation that Christ is even now accomplishing. The God of Christianity will leave nothing undone or even halfway done. On the contrary, the Word incarnate will dispel every ounce of darkness, conquer every form of evil, heal every disease, and put right every wrong. He will restore “every aspect” of human beings. He will bring to fruition the fullness of God’s purposes for God’s creation.

The challenge before us now is to say how it is that, in Jesus Christ, God is redeeming the whole world and fulfilling his good purposes for creation. After all, when we look around, it doesn’t appear that much has changed. If anything, many people, including some Christians, believe that things are only getting worse. Thus, we need to answer the following question: How, precisely, does Jesus save?

The New Testament uses an astounding range of terms and metaphors to refer to the saving work of Christ and its effects. Language is appropriated from ^[368]the courtroom, the battlefield, the marketplace, and the home. Drawing upon the important Old Testament background, the New Testament authors employ an astounding range of ways of talking about what Christ has accomplished. As Joel B. Green notes, “Paul can write of substitution, representation, sacrifice, justification, forgiveness, reconciliation, triumph over the powers, redemption, and more,” while “John can speak of illumination as well as sacrifice,” as “Hebrews presents Jesus as both the perfect

high priest and the perfect sacrificial victim,” and “1 Peter speaks of Jesus’s death as a ransom and sacrifice,” even as Revelation “presents Jesus’s death in terms of military triumph and redemption.”⁵ This great breadth of perspective helps us better understand the nature of Christ’s saving work on behalf of sinners, and it calls for further exploration.

9.2. The Saving Significance of the Incarnation

9.2.1. Recapitulation

Our understanding of what Christ did on our behalf is grounded in, and retains the closest connection to, who the incarnate Son of God *is* as the one Mediator between God and humanity who is both divine and human. The theme of *recapitulation* is thus bedrock for the doctrine of the atonement. It enjoys strong biblical support, and it was among the most popular ways of understanding Christ’s saving significance in the early church.

We should understand the work of Christ on our behalf within the storyline of Scripture: “Christ died for our sins in accordance with the scriptures” (1 Cor 15:3). His work addresses our condition—both the guilt and the pollution. Jesus Christ reverses the disobedience and unfaithfulness of Adam and Israel. Drawing on an ancient theological insight, we can say that in becoming human the divine Son of God recapitulates (or “re-heads”) humanity. **Thus, the incarnation is itself redemptive.** Indeed, as we will see, Christ’s entire life, death, and resurrection (as well as his ascension and session) brings salvation to us.

The apostle Paul draws an explicit comparison and contrast between Adam and Christ. In Romans, he tells us that “sin came into the world through one man, and death came through sin, and so death spread to all because all have sinned” (Rom 5:12). Adam’s “transgression” brings disaster to all humanity, for “the many died through the one man’s trespass” (Rom 5:15). But Adam is not ultimate, for ^[369]Paul tells us that he was only a “type of the one who was to come” (Rom 5:14). Jesus Christ, the second (or last) Adam, also represents and “re-heads” humanity. Paul lays out the contrasts starkly: “The free gift is not like the trespass” (Rom 5:15). Divine judgment following the sin brings condemnation, but “the free gift following many trespasses brings justification” (Rom 5:16). And while the death that follows the trespass “exercised dominion through that one, much more surely will those who receive the abundance of grace and the free gift of righteousness exercise dominion in life through the one man, Jesus Christ” (Rom 5:17). While the sin of the first Adam opened the floodgates of death and condemnation, the work of the second Adam brings life and justification. For “where sin increased, grace abounded all the more, so that, just as sin exercised dominion in death, so grace might also exercise dominion through justification leading to eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord” (Rom 5:20–21).

To sum up, Jesus Christ, the eternal Son of God incarnate as human for us and for our salvation, is the reconstitution of Israel, “re-heading” (*anakephalaiōsasthai*) humanity and “all things” in heaven and on earth (Eph 1:10).⁶ This insight exercises profound impact in the theological ruminations of the theologians of the early church. As J. N. D. Kelly puts it, “Running through almost all the patristic attempts to explain the redemption there is one grand theme which . . . provides the clue to the fathers’ understanding of the work of Christ. This is none other than the ancient idea of recapitulation which Irenaeus derived from Saint Paul, and which envisages Christ as the representative of the entire race.”⁷ For “just as all men were somehow present in Adam, so they are, or can be, present in the second Adam, the man from heaven. Just as they were involved in the former’s sin, with all its appalling consequences, so they can participate in the latter’s death and ultimate triumph over sin, the

forces of evil and death itself.”⁸ Irenaeus himself explains the point like this: “But when He became incarnate, and was made man, He commenced afresh the long line of human beings, and furnished us, in a brief, comprehensive manner, with salvation; so that what we had lost in Adam—namely to be according to the image and likeness of God—that we might recover in Christ Jesus.”⁹

[370]Why was this view so popular in the early church? One reason has to do with aesthetics or beauty. Recapitulation represents both symmetry and poetic justice. Just as sin came through one man, so grace and salvation now come through one man. As Joshua McNall says, “Irenaeus was attempting to counter false teachings with a story that was superior not only in logical coherence and biblical attestation but in beauty and poetic justice.” McNall continues,

The gospel was not only truer than Gnostic mythology; it was more winsome. In the divine economy, the reflection of God’s goodness was to be encountered not merely in the rationality of the immaterial mind but in the physicality of a fallen but majestic world. . . . For Irenaeus, the splendor of the aesthetic criterion was leveraged . . . to show that God’s acts within creation reveal the marks of providence just as beauty has the ring of truth. In this way, connections between the first and second Adam were seen to give more credence to the Christian faith.¹⁰

In addition to the persuasive power of poetic justice, recapitulation reflects an important biblical concept, namely, representation. Beyond the negative example of Adam as fallen humanity’s representative head, the Bible also portrays representation in a more positive light. For instance, when David fights and defeats Goliath, he does so on behalf of the Israelite people who reap the benefits of his victory. As McNall puts it, “In the Bible, the head may act for the whole.”¹¹ As the perfect embodiment of the *imago Dei*—indeed, its archetype—Jesus Christ himself is our new representative who generously shares with us his conquering of sin and death.

If we are to understand the persuasive power of recapitulation, we must add one more dimension, namely, the totality of Christ’s life and work. In other words, it isn’t just Christ’s being born of the Virgin Mary that enables him to re-head humanity and to be our representative. Rather, the Word incarnate reforms in his life, death, and resurrection the entire history of humankind. Christ redeems human life by passing through all its stages. He is the second Adam who, like the first Adam, is conceived without a human father. He is tempted by Satan, but unlike the first Adam, he does not succumb. Like the first Adam, he dies. But unlike the first Adam, he overcomes death in his resurrection. Thus, through the totality of [371]his life, death, and resurrection, Christ restores humanity to its original pattern, which is none other than himself, the archetype. As Irenaeus says, “Then, at last, he came even to death itself, that he might be ‘the first-born from the dead, that in all things he might have the pre-eminence,’ the prince of life, *existing before all, and going before all.*”¹²

To summarize, Jesus Christ can save us because, at one and the same time, he is both *like* us and *unlike* us. On the one hand, his experiences are sufficiently like ours for him to be truly human. He is born. He lives and develops as a human being. He knows what it means to be hungry. He is tempted by sin. And he dies. On the other hand, his life is so sufficiently unlike our lives that he can change our condition. He does not succumb to temptation. He does not sin. He is obedient to the will of the Father. He conquers death and the grave.

9.2.2. Participation

Himself the original archetype of humanity, the Word incarnate is the pattern for humanity. He shows us how we were intended to live. He displays for us what human life fully conformed to the image of God looks like. He

doesn't do this just because he can or just so that we can gaze helplessly at what we should have been but, due to sin and fallenness, can never be. On the contrary, the well-known exchange formula found in so many of the early church fathers declares that the Word became human so that we might become divine.¹³ This does not mean that we will cease to be human or that the distinction between us and God will be eliminated. Rather, it means that, just as the Word was joined to human flesh, so we will be united with him. Joined to him, we become "partakers of the divine nature" (2 Pet 1:4 KJV). Thus, the closely related ideas of union and participation are of crucial importance when it comes to the saving significance of the incarnation.

But just how are we joined to Christ? And what benefit is it to us? These are crucial questions, and it is not clear that recapitulation can answer them without turning elsewhere for help, most notably, the work of the Holy Spirit in the sacramental life of the church. Union with Christ is something that the Spirit does for us and in us. Just as it was by the Spirit that the Word became incarnate of the Virgin Mary, so now it is by the Spirit that we are joined to Christ.¹⁴

^[372]We should also mention that, in viewing Jesus not only as the new representative "head" but also as the archetype in whose image all human beings are made, advocates of recapitulation sometimes talk as though our connection to the Word has to do with human nature as such. Thus, recapitulation does not always give sufficient emphasis to the Word becoming a particular human person. Of course, recapitulation can easily be understood in such a way that the flesh that the Word becomes is the flesh of a particular human being, namely, Jesus of Nazareth. Even so, the emphasis in the tradition is often on the whole of humanity being related to the Word as archetype—a relation that makes him our only rightful head. This emphasis on all humanity being related to Christ makes recapitulation especially attractive for Wesleyans, as it coheres well with the doctrine of the unlimited atonement, which we have already discussed at length in connection with election. Olin A. Curtis, a Wesleyan theologian, stresses the saving significance of the incarnation in a way that has much in common with classical accounts of recapitulation. Curtis writes, "Out of the Adamic race, broken in organism, and doomed to destruction as a race, the work of Christ is to secure a new race completely personal, completely organic, and completely holy," and he concludes that "the Incarnation was more than a preparation for the atonement; it was also the provision of a dynamic center for the new race."¹⁵

Anytime there is an emphasis on unlimited atonement, the question of universalism is never far off. In this case, we can ask, If all people are united to the Word by virtue of his being the archetype of humanity, as well as through his universal headship, then will not all people be saved? Thomas F. Torrance is representative of the vast chorus of theologians who do not think so. On the one hand, Torrance acknowledges that Christ is the head of all and died for all, saying, "As the creator and head of the race in whom all mankind consist, Christ died for all men and women, and the justification involved is total, for all."¹⁶ On the other hand, Torrance goes on to say, "If anyone goes to hell, they go to hell, only because, inconceivably, they refuse the positive act of the divine acceptance of them" and refuse to acknowledge that God has taken their rejection of him upon himself, so acknowledging that they deserve to be rejected."¹⁷

These challenges notwithstanding, recapitulation is securely grounded in Scripture and enjoys strong support in early Christian theology and beyond.¹⁸ It ^[373]stands in the tradition as a reminder that the whole of Christ's life and work is of saving significance, beginning with the incarnation itself. The incarnation is far more than a necessary precondition for Christ's suffering and death on the cross (i.e., the Son must be born before he can suffer and die).

In summary, the following points are of critical importance. First, the Son of God became fully and completely human to "re-head" the human race. Accordingly, as Marilyn McCord Adams says, "It is within the framework of his human personality that God especially befriends the whole human race, not least by sharing both our vulnerability to and our actual participation in horrors."¹⁹ Second, he became incarnate not simply to begin anew but to finish the job; he came not merely to display solidarity but to bring salvation. Third, it is thus

of vital importance for human sinners to participate in what he came to do. Fourth, and finally, the doctrine of recapitulation neither offers an independent and more or less complete explanation of Christ's saving work nor eliminates the need for reflection on other key biblical insights. Thus, we agree with Fleming Rutledge when she says, "Compelling as Irenaeus's account is, it does not incorporate and make sense of Christ's gruesome death."²⁰ Even so, recapitulation establishes a firm foundation for consideration of other biblically based ways of understanding the saving work of Christ. As Irenaeus himself recognizes, in Christ, God recapitulates humanity so that "he might kill sin, deprive death of its power, and vivify man."²¹

9.3. The Saving Significance of Christ's Life and Teachings

Certain sectors of the Christian tradition have emphasized the work of Christ in setting an example for his followers in his life and death. In particular, the tradition of liberal Protestantism in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries placed strong emphasis on this theme and sometimes held that it is the only legitimate way to think about the life and death of Christ. Two main elements are prominent in such an approach. The first is the conviction that Christ's life is an example for others to emulate. According to the nineteenth-century Anglican theologian Hastings Rashdall, "The clear, unmistakable, invariable teaching of Jesus was that men were to be judged according to their works, including in the conception of ^[374]works the state of the heart and intentions."²² The basic idea is not hard to understand: We are to do good works in love of God and neighbor, and Jesus Christ is the ultimate moral exemplar who not only reveals God's love for us and willingness to forgive but also demonstrates for us how to live righteously. In addition to this, a second element is often added to the theory. This is the notion that, in addition to being a moral example, Christ's work empowers us as a moral influence for good. Thus, as Friedrich Schleiermacher says, "The Redeemer assumes believers into the power of his God-consciousness, and this is his redemptive activity."²³

9.3.1. What Would Jesus Do?

Perhaps largely due to the tendency of liberal Protestantism to isolate this account as the only legitimate way of thinking of Christ's work and the accompanying proclivity to attack other accounts, there has been a backlash against moral exemplar and influence. The now common criticism in some quarters is that moral exemplar and influence shift the emphasis in theology away from the question, What has Jesus done? to the question, What would Jesus do? In the process, so the argument goes, the *objective* work of Christ on the cross recedes into the background to the point that it is barely perceptible.²⁴ Colin Gunton, a late twentieth-century English Reformed theologian, speaks for many when he says, "In place of an act of God" centered in the "historic life and death" of Jesus "towards the otherwise helpless," the emphasis is now on "those who by appropriate action [can] help themselves."²⁵

While the insight that Christ is both a moral example and one who influences us morally is inadequate as a full-orbed and comprehensive account of the work of Christ, it nonetheless contains important insights. Just because it cannot do *all* the work does not mean that it cannot do *any* of it. Besides, the same holds, as we ^[375]have seen, for recapitulation, and a good case can be made that none of the major views concerning *how* Christ saves captures the totality of his saving work.²⁶

Like recapitulation, the idea that Christ is a moral exemplar and moral influence is grounded in Scripture and affirmed widely in the Christian tradition. Most famously, the apostle Paul exhorts the Corinthian church to imitate him as he imitates Christ Jesus (1 Cor 11:1). Elsewhere, Peter tells us that “Christ also suffered for you, leaving you an example, so that you should follow in his steps” (1 Pet 2:21). And John insists that “whoever says ‘I abide in him,’ ought to walk just as he walked” (1 John 2:6).

Moral exemplar and influence themes can also be seen in much Christian theology and devotional literature. Late medieval Catholic devotional handbooks, the most famous being Thomas à Kempis’s *Imitation of Christ* (AD 1427), set forth spiritual practices designed to assist Christians in following Christ’s example for how to live. Many of these, including Thomas’s, stressed withdrawal and detachment from the world, no doubt reflecting the monastic setting in which they were written. In modern Protestantism, moral exemplar and influence views of Christ’s saving significance became especially popular through the widespread reception of Charles Sheldon’s devotional classic, *In His Steps* (1896), a work credited with inspiring the “What would Jesus do?” movement today.

9.3.2. Infused Love

Beyond popular spiritual and devotional works, moral exemplar views of Christ’s saving work are frequently associated with the work of Peter Abelard (1079–1142). This is due largely to a fascinating passage in Abelard’s commentary on Rom 3:19–26. For Abelard, the sheer violence of Christ’s suffering and death on the cross raises some serious questions. Above all, Abelard asked an entirely sensible question, namely, If Christ’s suffering death was to atone for human sin, what atones for the murder of God’s only Son? In response to this question, Abelard writes,

It seems to us that in this we are justified in the blood of Christ and reconciled to God, that it was through this matchless grace shown to us that his son received our nature and in that nature, *teaching us both by word and by example*, preserved to the death and bound us to himself even more through love, so that when we have been kindled by so great a benefit of divine grace, true charity might fear to endure nothing for his sake. . . . Therefore, our redemption is that ^[376]supreme love in us through the Passion of Christ, which not only frees us from slavery to sin, but gains for us the true liberty of the sons of God, so that we may complete all things by his love rather than by fear.²⁷

Abelard’s views would be roundly condemned by both Bernard of Clairvaux (1090–1153) and William of Saint Thierry (1075–1148).²⁸ The problem, they claimed, was that on this account, Christ merely teaches or commands righteousness; he does not actually bestow it. In other words, Christ does not secure salvation in a way that involves the mediation of saving grace to us.

In hindsight, this is an uncharitable critique of Abelard’s position. For starters, he elsewhere clearly advocates for penal substitution (see below for more on this view). Thus, he does not restrict Christ’s view to his being a moral exemplar. More importantly, though, Abelard seems to have believed that Christ’s passion does in fact result in the mediation of saving grace, insofar as it inflames our hearts with love for God and neighbor. Even in the controversial text quoted above, he clearly thinks that Christ’s life kindles in us a love that sets us free from bondage to fear. As Paul Fiddes, a contemporary Baptist theologian, says, for Abelard “the revelation of Christ, when received by the human mind, is at the same time an actual infusion of love.”²⁹ Abelard, says Fiddes, “grasped the power of the divine love to *create* or generate love in human beings.”³⁰

Much the same can be said of more contemporary formulations of moral influence. Thus, Schleiermacher says, “Indeed Christ’s highest achievement consists in this, that He so animates us that we ourselves are led to an ever more perfect fulfillment of the divine will.”³¹ However, as with recapitulation, the real problem with both the more charitable reading of Abelard and more recent formulations of moral exemplar or influence is that they do not tell us *how* this happens. Abelard does not tell us how we become enflamed or kindled with love for God and neighbor. Nor does Schleiermacher adequately explain how Christ animates us to perfectly fulfill the divine will. It is not clear, for instance, that there is any difference between Christ’s inspiring us to love or animating us to fulfill the divine will^[377] and an athlete inspiring us to exercise or pursue excellence in a sport. In short, moral exemplar and influence views often struggle to say how, precisely, we can imitate Christ. Apart from an account of the enabling and empowering work of the Holy Spirit, they risk reducing salvation to sheer inspired effort. The problem with this is easy to see. However inspired I might be by watching Tiger Woods play golf, I am not likely to attain anything like his grace and ability on the golf course simply by trying harder or practicing more.

The emphasis on being liberated from fear and being motivated instead by love makes moral exemplar or influence views of Christ’s saving work especially appealing to Wesleyans. John Wesley himself frequently speaks of the fear of God as merely a stage on the way to true faith and true religion. Real Christianity, he insists, occurs only when we move from fear to love in our relationship to God and to our neighbors.³² However, Wesley does something that Abelard and Schleiermacher do not. Wesley explains *how* this love is inflamed or kindled with us, namely, by the indwelling presence and work of the Holy Spirit. Of course, Wesley is not alone in this emphasis. On the contrary, as we will see when we take up the person and work of the Spirit, Augustine himself conceived of the Spirit in just this way. Moving in the opposite direction, which is to say, closer to the present day, Sarah Coakley, a contemporary Anglican theologian, likewise stresses the necessity of the Spirit’s indwelling and sanctifying work. Following Augustine closely, Coakley insists that the Spirit enflames our hearts with love for God and neighbor.³³

Pneumatological adjustments to moral exemplar and influence notwithstanding, at least one significant problem remains. It is hard to see how moral exemplar or influence accounts for the uniqueness of Christ as the Savior of the world. He is an example, to be sure, but it is not clear that he is altogether unique in being so. On the contrary, human history is full of people who have led exemplary lives of love for God and neighbor, some to the point of martyrdom. But we do not worship such people as God, we do not ascribe saving significance to the way they lived or died, and, simply put, we do not trust them for salvation.³⁴

^[378]On a more positive note, moral exemplar and influence call our attention to Christ’s teachings and to the way that he lived perhaps better than any other view of Christ’s saving work. For this reason alone, they make a significant contribution to our understanding of how Christ saves. While other views may help us to grapple more with the saving significance of Christ’s suffering and death, if we fail to emphasize obedience to Christ’s teachings, and by extension to the will of his Father, our understanding of how Christ saves will be greatly diminished. We will struggle to answer the all-important question, How then shall we live? And we will be prone to forget Jesus’s teaching that his true family and the true disciples are those who imitate him in the doing of his Father’s will (Matt 12:50; Mark 3:35).

9.4. The Saving Significance of Christ’s Suffering and Death

With recapitulation and moral exemplar views of Christ’s saving work, we have been focused primarily on the saving significance of the incarnation, life, and teachings of Christ. We must now shift our attention to the ways

in which Scripture and the Christian tradition have understood the saving significance of Christ's suffering and death on the cross. Specifically, we will attend to the themes of sacrifice, satisfaction, and substitution.

9.4.1. Sacrifice

To say that Christ “died in accordance with the Scriptures” is to see his work within the broad biblical storyline. This includes seeing it in the light of the Old Testament witness to both the wrath of God and the sacrifices offered for sin. The New Testament draws these connections, and it presents Jesus as the one who is both priest and sacrifice, both representative and substitute. Jesus's death is understood as an offering and an exchange —“the righteous for the unrighteous” (1 Pet 3:18). He comes “in the likeness of sinful flesh” to be a sin offering and to condemn “sin in the flesh” (Rom 8:3). He redeems us from the curse of the law by “becoming a curse for us” (Gal 3:13). We are “saved through him from the wrath of God” (Rom 5:9; 1 Thess 1:10). The one who was sinless (e.g., Heb 4:15) and who “knew no sin” became “sin” on our behalf (2 Cor 5:21). Jesus Christ—the sinless Son of God incarnate—“bore our sins in his body on the cross, so that, free from sins, we might live for righteousness” (1 Pet 2:24; cf. Isa 53:5–6).

^[379]Two major themes are especially relevant here. The first is that of sacrifice; Jesus is said in Scripture to be a “sin offering” (Rom 8:3; 2 Cor 5:21 NIV). He comes as both the high priest and the sacrifice; “for the author of Hebrews,” as David M. Moffitt explains, “the preexistent heavenly Son becomes the human high priest, Jesus, who performed the ultimate atoning sacrifice in the Holy of Holies (Heb 9:11–12, 24; cf. 4:14; 6:19–20; 8:1–5)” and “thereby accomplished redemption and purification, as well as forgiveness/removal of sins for God's people.”³⁵ As the eternal Son of God now incarnate as Jesus Christ, he is the final “sin offering” who brings atonement.

Speaking of Christ's sacrifice on the cross is clearly patterned after the ritual sacrifice of animals in ancient Israel, most notably, the Passover lamb. Thus, our first instinct might be to dismiss this way of thinking about Christ's work as outdated and unhelpful. After all, very few people today practice animal sacrifice. However, the metaphor is simply too prominent in Scripture and the Christian tradition for us simply to set it aside or ignore it. As Frances Young says, “For the early church, sacrifice was an image which could focus with peculiar intensity the full significance of the life and death of Christ for the salvation of the world.”³⁶

So how can the category of sacrifice help us to think about the saving significance of Christ's death on the cross? Above all, sacrifice forces us to come to terms with the fact that, like Israel, we have disobeyed God's commandments. We have failed to uphold God's gracious covenant with us. And by the terms of the covenant itself, this means that we are deserving of punishment. This constitutes something of a dilemma for God or, at the very least, for our understanding of God's nature. Given our commitment to simplicity, God is supremely and entirely merciful and good. However, he is also supremely and entirely just. With this in mind, we must ask, How should God, who is merciful, good, and just, deal with human sin?

Conceiving of Christ as a sacrifice is one of the major ways that Scripture and the early church attempt to resolve this dilemma. As Young says, Christ's suffering and death comes to be seen as “a sort of ‘self-propitiation’ offered by God to God to make atonement for the existence of evil in his universe.”³⁷ In other words, in Christ, God takes it upon himself to pay the penalty for sin and to make amends for our failure to keep the covenant.

But if we are really to see the power of the concept of sacrifice for understanding Christ's saving work on the cross, then we need to notice its connection with the life of the church and especially worship—itsself, a kind of sacrifice. Thus, Young says,

^[380]For the early Church, there was an intimate relationship between the sacrifice of Christ and the sacrificial worship and service of the Church; there was an indissoluble bond linking Christ's sacrifice of obedience to the spiritual sacrifices of the saint and the martyr. . . . When we see the sacrifice of Christ in the context of the worshipping community, we have a new perspective. The believing Christian does not simply enter as an individual into a moral and emotional identification with Christ . . . but takes his place in a community which is, or at least attempts to be, the body of Christ on earth.³⁸

The linking of Christ's sacrifice with Christian worship takes place especially in the sacrament of the Lord's Supper.³⁹ Young continues, "The sacrifice of the eucharist was the culmination of a total spiritual cult involving the whole life and service of Christians. It was the self-offering of Christians in response to the self-offering of Christ—and not simply a response, for this was not another offering but the same offering as his, redeemed humanity united in offering homage to God."⁴⁰

The close connection between Christ's making a sacrifice for sin and the sacrifice made weekly in Holy Communion in early and medieval Christian theology will eventually be overshadowed in Protestant theology by a way of thinking about the saving significance of Christ's death on the cross that revolves around the concept of *substitution*. However, before we get to substitutionary views, we should take a moment to examine another crucial concept in the church's understanding of the saving significance of Christ's death on the cross, namely, *satisfaction*. Chiefly associated with Anselm of Canterbury (and, in a very different form, Thomas Aquinas), satisfaction has much in common with both sacrifice and substitution. In some ways, it represents a stage in the ongoing development of the doctrine of the atonement between early and medieval Christian theology's focus on Christ as sacrifice and the later Protestant emphasis on Christ as substitute.

9.4.2. Satisfaction

The basic idea of satisfaction has to do with "making amends or reparation; specifically, the making amends for sin required by God."⁴¹ The doctrine is sometimes ^[381]caricatured as a crude repayment of a debt to divine honor, but the basic idea is grounded in the biblical witness to reconciliation. For the New Testament includes both indicative statements of reconciliation—"while we were enemies, we were reconciled to God through the death of his Son" (Rom 5:10)—and imperative statements: "be reconciled to God" (2 Cor 5:20). The identity of Christ as both divine and human is vitally important here, for it is *as God* that he brings reconciliation and *as human* that he receives it from our side and includes us within it as we are drawn into union with him.

It is important to avoid some common misperceptions here. First, we should see that the New Testament discussions of reconciliation never talk about some divine need to be reconciled to us; instead, the New Testament repeatedly tells us that God was in Christ reconciling the world to himself and then, in turn, imploring us to be reconciled to God (2 Cor 5:19). And, second, in no sense is it true that Christ somehow changes God by what he does. As Aquinas points out, "Christ is not said to have reconciled us with God, as if God had begun anew to have love for us, since it is written (Jer 31:3 KJV): 'I have loved thee with an everlasting love'; but because the source of hatred was taken away by Christ's passion, both through the sin being washed away and through compensation being made to God in the shape of a more pleasing offering."⁴²

With these important reminders in place, we should also note that, like sacrifice, the concept of satisfaction is somewhat foreign today. We simply don't use the word "satisfaction" in the same way that medieval Christians did. For most people today, the concept of satisfaction simply has to do with being happy or content with an

arrangement or outcome. For instance, we may declare that our favorite team's victory was satisfying. But this is not how the concept is understood and used in medieval Christianity. In that setting, satisfaction plays an essential part in the obtaining of forgiveness. For someone like Anselm of Canterbury, the practice of penance would have involved three distinct acts: contrition (sorrow for what we have done), confession (acknowledging or admitting what we have done), and satisfaction (making amends for what we have done). In response to penance, the priest would have pronounced forgiveness or absolution.

Protestants sometimes recoil at the idea of satisfaction as a means of procuring forgiveness. Yet we clearly understand the role of satisfaction in our relations with one another. Suppose we do something to disappoint our spouses. Sooner or later, this is bound to happen. Because we love our spouses and don't want to disappoint them, we feel terrible about whatever it is that we have done. To express that we are sorry and to make amends, we might bring a gift for our spouse or offer to ^[382]do something special the following day. We are genuinely trying to make things right. We are trying to express that we are sorry and make satisfaction for what we have done.

Unfortunately, what sometimes works in our relations with one another does not work in our relationship to God. Why not? Because disobedience to God is exponentially worse on account of God's infinite worth and the fact that our sin has led to disharmony and disorder in God's beautiful creation. We simply cannot give God anything that will make up for the damage that we have done. So unless another means of satisfaction presents itself, our punishment will be the only way to honor God's justice.

Satisfaction presupposes that God is essentially just, and it recognizes that divine justice is retributive in nature.⁴³ It sees sin as truly horrific, not only for what it does to the sinner but also for the way that it disrespects and dishonors God and disfigures and destroys God's good creation. It admits that the penalty for sin must be sufficient or appropriate to the offense. Satisfaction then works to provide an account of how that penalty for sin might be accounted for—either sin must be punished, or some action must be done that goes above and beyond (an act of supererogation) what is always and already owed to God.⁴⁴ It is precisely *this action* that is performed by Christ. Indeed, it can be done only by Christ, for he is the only sinless one. As Anselm famously concludes, because “no one can pay except God, and no one ought to pay except man; it is necessary that a God-Man should pay it.”⁴⁵

For Anselm, the incarnation is the *necessary* precondition for Christ's death on the cross to be of saving significance. Who Christ is—the God-man—is what makes him capable of saving us through his suffering and death on the cross. Because he is human, Christ is able to suffer and die. Because he is divine, he cannot sin, and so he does not *have* to die. Because Christ's life is of infinite worth, his sacrifice on our behalf is a sufficient recompense for sin. Christ alone could pay our debt. And he did just that. In the words of Elvina Hall's beloved nineteenth-century hymn, “Jesus paid it all.”

The thing that we need to see here is that, for Anselm, as for the early Fathers who conceived of Christ's death in terms of sacrifice, choosing between mercy and justice is impossible for God. God is entirely merciful *and* entirely just. There can be no setting aside of one or the other. God isn't merciful on Tuesdays and just on Saturdays. Consequently, when it comes to responding to our idolatry ^[383]and our destruction of creation, God's choice is not between mercy and justice but between punishment and satisfaction. Also like the early proponents of sacrifice, for Anselm, Christ's suffering and death on the cross is not the whole story. Satisfaction is not simply about securing our place in heaven. It is also about our becoming active participants in all that God is doing to restore “the order and beauty of the universe.”⁴⁶

But how do we do that? How do we participate in God's renewal of order and beauty? One possibility hinted at in the *Cur Deus Homo*? is that we do so by imitating Christ. But Anselm never really explains how we can do that. Imitating Christ sounds like a worthwhile goal. It also sounds like an impossible one, especially when we consider all that Christ commands of us. In the Gospel of Matthew, Jesus says that whoever wants to be

his disciple, or his family, must be willing to give up everything to follow him (Matt 16:24–26). Everything, it turns out, includes homes, possessions, and wealth. It includes our spouses and our families. Those who submit to Christ must also be willing to go defenseless in the world. The one who would be Christ's disciple must deny herself and take up her cross. She must be willing to imitate Christ in the wilderness in foregoing the allure of position and power. She must be ready to share all that she has with others.

A more likely explanation is that we must be joined to Christ by the Holy Spirit through participation in the sacramental life of the church and especially through regular reception of the sacrament. Given his medieval monastic setting, it is safe to say that Anselm presupposes such regular participation in the Eucharist. Thus, viewing the saving significance of Christ's death on the cross through the lens of satisfaction is very much like viewing it through the lens of sacrifice: The benefits of Christ's work, namely, all manner of saving grace, are conferred to us through the sacraments.⁴⁷

9.4.3. Substitution

With this in mind, we are now ready to consider a third way of thinking about the saving significance of Christ's death on the cross, namely, *substitution*, or what is sometimes known as penal substitution.⁴⁸ Like sacrifice and satisfaction (when ^[384]associated with reconciliation), the concept of substitution can be seen in the New Testament. Jesus is "handed over to death for our trespasses" (Rom 4:25), and he dies as the "righteous for the unrighteous" (1 Pet 3:18).⁴⁹ Recognition of the reality of substitutionary atonement is found throughout the Christian tradition as well, but it is especially prominent in Protestant theology. It is affirmed by both Martin Luther and John Calvin.⁵⁰ In the midst of canvassing all the major views of the atonement, John Wesley could go so far as to call Christ's substitutionary death the "very center and marrow of the gospel."⁵¹

The foundation or starting point for understanding substitution is Christ's *identification* with us. Eleonore Stump suggests that Jesus has "joint attention" with the entire human race such that he personally experiences our guilt and alienation from God.⁵² He is the one who suffers vicariously. Indeed, there is a sense in which it can be said that the work of Christ is an act of *penal* substitution. As William Lane Craig defines it, this is the doctrine "that God inflicted upon Christ the suffering that we deserved as the punishment for our sins, as a result of which we no longer deserve punishment." As Craig notes, "This explication leaves open the question whether Christ was punished for our sins" (and thus avoids many concerns of the "governmental theories" that were popular in Wesleyan theology in the nineteenth century).⁵³

Several cautionary notes are in order here. First, as we have just noted, the doctrine does not demand commitment to the conclusion that God punished Jesus. Such a notion strikes many theologians as deeply problematic, but it is *not* part of the classical understanding of the doctrine. Second, we should avoid all statements that see atonement as exacting in a pecuniary sense or insist that the punishment must be strictly retributive. Third, we should resist all notions of ^[385]strife within God; whether the alleged conflict is between the divine attributes or between the Father and the Son, we should understand that there simply is no good biblical basis for such claims. For the only scriptural text that could be taken to address the question of the Father turning his face away from the Son explicitly says that he did *not* do so—"he did not hide his face from me, but heard when I cried to him" (Ps 22:24). Thus, we should insist upon the reality of the doctrines of simplicity and the Trinity and strive to understand the work of Christ in the light of those doctrines. Simply put, there is no broken Trinity or strife of attributes within God.⁵⁴ Fourth, and closely related, we should avoid all pagan notions of propitiation and reject all suggestions that Jesus somehow changed God or absorbed all the Father's wrath while shielding us with his love.⁵⁵ To the contrary, as Thomas F. Torrance says, "God does not love us because of the atoning propitiation enacted in the sacrificial death of Christ. Rather does that propitiation flow freely from

the consistent self-movement of the Love that God himself is,” for “it is through the sheer overflow of his eternal Love that God has provided for mankind atoning propitiation in the blood of Christ.”⁵⁶ In the words of John Stott, “God’s love is the *source*, not the *consequence*, of the atonement.”⁵⁷

As with the concepts of sacrifice and satisfaction, it is important to understand that the point of substitution is not to focus on merely avoiding punishment or going to heaven. Note carefully the statement “so that, free from sins, we might live for righteousness” (1 Pet 2:24). We cannot afford to miss the *union* and *participation* here—Christ lived with and for us and died for our sins so that we might die to our sins and live with and for him. Nor can we afford to miss the intention; it is so that *we* might be transformed, so that *we* might be truly righteous. Christ was a sacrifice for us so that we might live as people who are holy (e.g., Eph 5:2–21). His sacrifice was to “remove sin” (Heb 9:26). It was to *cleanse us* from sin—the “dead works” (Heb 9:14). Christ was a “sin offering” precisely so that we will “walk not according to the flesh but according to the Spirit” (Rom 8:4)—so that “we might become the righteousness of God” (2 Cor 5:21). As a result of Christ’s work, we can be “freed . . . from our sins” by the one who loves us (Rev 1:5 NIV). We should ^[386]therefore be committed to proclaiming all that Scripture says about what Christ did for us. We should not shrink from clarity about sin and its awful and horrific consequences—including the biblical witness to the wrath of God. Indeed, we should be faithful to point out that “wrath remains” on all who reject the Son (John 3:36 NIV). At the same time, however, we are not at liberty to limit our understanding of the intents, purposes, and breadth of Christ’s work. To view Christ’s work only in terms of taking the punishment for our sins is to miss (much of) the point—yes, Christ came to get us out of hell, but he also came to get the hell out of us. We should be faithful to proclaim that, while Christ’s sacrificial work saves us from the wrath of God, it does so precisely as it radically transforms and changes *us*.

Once again, the question is this: How does this happen? How does Christ’s being our substitute change us? One possibility here is simply the evocation of gratitude. When we come to understand that, with respect to the punishment that we deserved, Christ took our place, the natural response should be living lives of deep gratitude to God. Unfortunately, human memory and will often turn out to be fickle things. Thus, more is clearly needed, and this is where Wesley is especially helpful, as he weds a substitutionary view of Christ’s death on the cross to a strong emphasis on the Spirit’s work of joining us to Christ through the sacramental life of the church. We will explore this theme at length in chapter 11. For now, suffice it to say that, as Wesleyans, we affirm that the Spirit mediates the transformational benefits of Christ’s work in the form of saving grace through word and sacrament as well as other means of grace.

Before moving on to yet another way of thinking about Christ’s saving work—a way that focuses on his resurrection—we should take a moment to note some common features of sacrifice, satisfaction, and substitution. All three of these views focus our attention on the saving significance of Christ’s suffering and death on the cross. All three envision Christ’s suffering and death as an expression or consequence of God’s eternally loving nature. In other words, they do not cause God to be or to become loving. At the same time, all three views take divine justice seriously. They refuse to wink at our sin and thereby make a mockery of God. As Frances Young says,

Atonement means a conviction that God has somehow dealt with evil, with sin, with rebellion. Perhaps the nearest we can get to expressing this is to say that on the cross, God in Christ entered into the suffering, the evil, and the sin of the world; he entered the darkness and transformed it into light, into blazing glory. He took responsibility for the existence of evil in his creation; he bore the pain of it and the guilt of it; he accepted its consequences into himself, and ^[387]in his love reconciled his holiness to a sinful and corrupt humanity, justifying the godly, accepting man just as he is.⁵⁸

Next, while Christ's suffering and death are central, the doctrine of inseparable operations prevents us from thinking or saying that the Father is doing something to the Son. Christ's suffering and death therefore do not amount to divine child abuse.⁵⁹ Rather, they are best viewed as God making good on God's own purposes for creation. This does not mean that sacrifice, satisfaction, and substitution should ever be used either to justify violence or to mandate that victims of abuse continue to suffer at the hands of their abusers. The once-for-all nature of Christ's work is important here, and the call to imitate Christ does not and cannot mean that we somehow repeat or complete his sacrificial and substitutionary work. As Morna Hooker says, "Christ's death and resurrection inaugurate a new situation which does away with the old."⁶⁰

Finally, while all three views regard Christ's suffering and death as, at the very least, fitting, if not strictly necessary as the just remedy for our sin, they all need help to show how they secure more than pardon for sin. In other words, something more is needed to say how Christ's suffering and death leads to our sanctification. And that something more is the work of the Holy Spirit in human lives and in the sacramental life of the church—themes we will explore in the next two chapters. For now, the time has come to consider Christ's saving work through the lens of ransom and *Christus Victor*.

9.5. The Saving Significance of Christ's Resurrection

To bring salvation, wholeness, and shalom to broken and rebellious sinners, Christ must defeat our ultimate enemies: sin, death, and the devil. And this is exactly what he does for his people. What is often referred to as the *Christus Victor* motif has been very influential in much Christian theology from the patristic era until today.⁶¹

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9.5.1. *Christus Victor*

As if anticipating Anselm's famous question, "Why the God-Human?" Hebrews says, "Since, therefore, the children share flesh and blood, he himself likewise shared the same things, so that through death he might destroy the one who has the power of death, that is, the devil, and free those who all their lives were held in slavery by the fear of death" (Heb 2:14–15). John is similarly unambiguous: "The Son of God was revealed for this purpose, to destroy the works of the devil" (1 John 3:8).

Building from this biblical basis (as well as from related New Testament passages and relevant Old Testament texts), theologians across the ages have recognized and emphasized the victory that Christ won by his redemptive work. Irenaeus, for example, says that the Son became human precisely to "destroy sin, overcome death, and give life to man." He explains further that humanity "had been created by God so that he might have life. If now, having lost life, and having been harmed by the serpent, he were not to return to life, but were to be wholly abandoned to death, then God would have been defeated, and the malice of the serpent would have overcome God's will. But since God is both invincible and longsuffering, he did show himself to be longsuffering . . . through the second Adam he bound the strong one, and spoiled his goods, and annihilated death, bringing life to man who had become subject to death."⁶²

Note how Irenaeus builds out this motif from the doctrine of recapitulation; the one who is victorious is the second Adam. As Gustaf Aulén says, "Incarnation and atoning work are thus set in the closest possible relation to one another; both belong to one scheme."⁶³ And note as well how Irenaeus connects this theme of victory drawn

from the picture of a cosmic battlefield with the legal element taken from the metaphor of the courtroom: “Wherefore he who had taken man captive was himself taken captive by God, and man who had been taken captive was set free from the bondage of condemnation.”⁶⁴

It is important to note that this decisive victory is won by the incarnate Son who is both divine *and fully human*. In other words, the victory was not accomplished simply by divine fiat or strictly from above. To the contrary, it was won from below, from our side, by one who has complete solidarity with feeble and fallen human creatures. Indeed, as Hebrews makes explicit, it was “through death” that the power of death was destroyed (Heb 2:14). It is also important to recognize^[389] that this motif is not opposed to or inconsistent with the other elements (e.g., sacrifice, satisfaction, and substitution). For the sober truth is that human sinners are not only helpless prisoners in desperate need of rescue—we are also willful rebels who have not loved our God with all our being or our neighbors as ourselves. We are much like Edmund in the *Chronicles of Narnia* as he sits helpless and hopeless in the house of the White Witch. Like Edmund, human sinners need a dramatic rescue from the prison of sin, but also like Edmund, we are in that prison because of what we have done. The upshot of this should be clear: **The *Christus Victor* motif is not an alternative to the other elements or motifs; rather, it is an important component of the bigger picture.**⁶⁵

9.5.2. Ransom

In principle, *Christus Victor* can assert that, in his death and resurrection, Jesus Christ has won a decisive victory over the devil without saying *how* he has done so. By contrast, ransom views of Christ’s saving work, which were prominent in the early church until the time of Anselm, portray Christ’s suffering and death and subsequent victory over the grave specifically in terms of the payment of a ransom to the devil. This notion can be controversial for obvious reasons. For instance, it might seem unbecoming for God to submit to the devil’s demand for a ransom in the first place. Who is the devil, the reasoning goes, to make demands of God? More generally, for modern and contemporary theologians who doubt the existence of the devil, or the demonic, such a payment makes no sense whatsoever.⁶⁶ Ransom views of Christ’s work simply represent an outdated worldview or mythology. They offer no meaningful help when it comes to answering the question, How does Jesus save? Finally, with respect to criticisms of ransom, there is the unseemly notion that God resorted to deceit.

Leaving aside for the moment denials of the devil’s existence that became high intellectual fashion in the modern period, we need to take a moment to examine what the early fathers of the church had in mind by ransom and how they countered the criticisms concerning whether the entire scheme coheres with our beliefs about the divine nature.⁶⁷ Early formulations of the doctrine often revolve^[390] around a fishhook analogy. The idea, including the analogy, is easy enough to understand. Satan, or the devil, held the whole human race captive because of sin—a captivity that culminates in our death. Seeing Jesus, a sinless human being, the devil was willing to swap the sinful human beings whom he held captive for Jesus. Unfortunately for the devil, he did not realize that Jesus was both human *and* divine. Jesus’s divine nature, according to Cyprian of Carthage, was like a fishhook hidden “by the covering of human flesh.”⁶⁸ Following the exchange of sinful human beings for the sinless one, the devil was able to have his way with Jesus, at least temporarily. Thus, Jesus suffers the penalty for our sin, namely, death. However, because he was divine, neither death nor the devil could hold Jesus in the grave, his true nature as the God-man being revealed on the day of his resurrection—a revelation that puts both death and the devil in their place, breaking their power not only over Christ himself but over the whole human race as well.

With this broad summary in place, we can now turn to the question whether this way of dealing with evil is befitting of God’s nature, including the matter of whether it involves the use of deceit. Gregory of Nyssa’s

But perhaps someone who has examined the justice and wisdom apparent in this plan is driven to conclude that such a scheme as God contrived for us involved deceit. For in a way it was a fraud and deception for God, when he placed himself in the power of the enemy who was our master, not to show his naked deity, but to conceal it in our nature, and so escape recognition. . . . But he who penetrates the truth of the matter will agree that we have here a crowning example of justice and wisdom.

Now it is the character of justice to render to each his due: It belongs to wisdom, on the other hand, neither to pervert justice nor to divorce its just decisions from the noble end of the love of man. Both must be skillfully combined. By justice due recompense is given; by goodness the end of the love of man is not excluded. . . . Justice is evident in the rendering of due recompense, by which the deceiver was in turn deceived. The purpose of the action, on the other hand, testifies to the goodness of him who brought it about. . . . By the principle of justice the deceiver reaps the harvest of the seeds he sowed with his own free will. For he who first deceived man by the bait of pleasure is ^[391]himself deceived by the camouflage of human nature. But the purpose of the action changes it into something good. For the one practiced deceit to ruin our nature; but the other, being at once just and good and wise, made use of a deceitful device to save the one who had been ruined. . . . For when death came into contact with life, darkness with light, corruption with incorruption, the worse of these things disappeared into a state of nonexistence, to the profit of him who was freed from these evils.⁶⁹

In some ways, Gregory's response on behalf of the ransom motif to charges of divine deceit amounts to this: God gives the devil his due. But it is more than that. God also takes decisive action on behalf of his purposes for creation and especially for us humans, refusing to leave us captive to evil.⁷⁰ This raises yet another important question, namely, What do we make of the evil that persists in the world today? If death and darkness and corruption "disappeared," as Gregory says, then why are they still with us?

We will look further at this issue in our discussion of eschatology, but it is important to observe that there is an eschatological tension in theology and in the Christian life at just this point. This is because, while it is completely true that Christ, in his death and resurrection, *decisively* defeated our ultimate enemy, it is also just as true that the *final* defeat of our enemy awaits the second coming and with it the general resurrection of the dead. And thus, living as we do between the already and the not yet—between the decisive defeat of the powers of evil in the death and resurrection of Christ and the final defeat at his second advent—we should expect the struggle against sin and the devil to continue.

To summarize, there is significant thematic overlap between the *Christus Victor* and ransom motifs. Most notably, both focus on Christ's defeat of the devil and death itself. And while it is true that Christ defeats death by death, which is to say, by suffering and dying, it is also true that the suffering and death of Christ would amount to a hollow victory (or no victory at all) had he not also been raised. Thus, both ransom and *Christus Victor* accentuate the saving significance of Christ's resurrection. In his resurrection, Christ conquers the grave and deals the devil a decisive, though not final, blow.

9.6. Prophet, Priest, and King

To this point, we have been thinking about Christ's saving work under the themes of recapitulation; moral exemplar and influence; sacrifice, satisfaction, and substitution; and ransom and *Christus Victor*. In doing so, we have underscored that the entirety of Christ's life and work is of saving significance. Jesus saves by becoming incarnate, through his life and teaching, and through his suffering, death, and resurrection. And his saving work is such that it overcomes every barrier that separates us from God. The various motifs or themes are simply the tradition's way of calling our attention to the fullness of Christ's saving work. Thus, we should not imagine the various motifs as competitors with one another, and we should be wary of trying to combine the various motifs into a single grand theory of Christ's atoning work. As tempting as the latter option might be, attempts to integrate or synthesize the major themes almost inevitably compromise the richness and fecundity of each individual theme. Across the centuries, theologians have freely and rightly deployed multiple motifs in their attempts to bear witness to Christ's saving work. For instance, Gregory of Nyssa can emphasize both recapitulation and ransom, saying, "This is what the resurrection means—the restoration of elements into an indissoluble union after their separation, so that they can grow together. In this way man's primal grace was restored and we retrieved once more eternal life. . . . Now just as the principle of death had its origin in a single person and passed to the whole of human nature, similarly the principle of the resurrection originated in one Man and extends to all humanity."⁷¹

While the classical themes canvassed above help us to understand how Christ saves, there is still another way to think about Christ's work. Scholastic Protestant theology gets at Christ's saving work through what has come to be known as the *munus triplex* or threefold office. As the incarnate person who is both fully human and fully divine, Jesus Christ takes upon himself the roles of Prophet, Priest, and King. He combines these prophetic, priestly, and royal roles together, not as first one and then another and then finally the third, and not as shifting back and forth between them as the occasion might demand. No, he combines them; as he is both fully human and fully divine in one person, so also, he is Prophet and Priest and King. He is the fulfillment of the promises and covenants that were made in the Old Testament, and he brings God's reign as he embodies God's presence.⁷²

^[393]Even so, it may help briefly to consider what is associated with each office. Christ's prophetic office (*munus*, or *officium propheticum*) includes both his teaching and the miracles. The priestly office (*munus sacerdotale*) focuses on the satisfaction or sacrifice that he makes for the sins of the world by his death on the cross and in his ongoing intercession on behalf of the world (*redemptio et intercessio sacerdotalis*). In his kingly office (*munus regium*), Christ reigns over all things in heaven and on earth. With this thumbnail sketch in place, let's take a closer look at the way Jesus embodies all three offices.

First, Jesus is announced by John the Baptist who thunders forth a call to repentance as he sees Jesus coming: "Repent. . . . Make straight the way of the Lord!" (Matt 3:2; John 1:23). Located initially within this stream, Jesus is the Prophet of God. But he is not just any prophet or just one more prophet. Jesus is the *final* Prophet, the ultimate revelation of God—God himself in human flesh. He is *like* the prophets of the Old Testament; he speaks truth to power, he faithfully warns of wrath and judgment that is to come for those who persist in rebellion and idolatry and injustice, he comforts the afflicted and brokenhearted, and he brings the promise of God's deliverance. He identifies with the people he is warning as well as the people he is comforting. He weeps for them. He weeps with them. He suffers with them. He suffers for them. He even willingly suffers *because* of them; he is faithful to them when they reject him and turn on him and hate him. But Jesus is also *unlike* the prophets of the Old Testament. For he not only announces God's judgment of sin and evil, but he brings it and even embodies it. He tells them about God, and he reveals God to them in his own person.

Second, Jesus Christ is the "great high priest" (Heb 4:14). Again, in some ways he is much like the priests of the Old Testament (and especially like Melchizedek) (cf. Heb 5:5–10). As Priest, he has two primary

responsibilities. On the one hand, in all that he does and indeed in his very person, he represents the people to God. On the other hand, he represents God to the people. He represents us not merely as one trying to sympathize from outside our condition; instead, he represents us precisely *as one of us*. As Hebrews tells us, “We do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who in every respect has been tested as we are, yet without sin” (Heb 4:15). And Jesus represents God to us not merely as one who “must offer sacrifice for his own sins as well as for those of the people” but instead as God himself—God incarnate, God become human, God made flesh (Heb 5:3). As Priest, he brings healing and wholeness. As Priest, he makes pronouncements about holiness—and actually makes people holy. Jesus is a Priest, but he is not merely a priest like other priests. He is *the great High Priest*. Indeed, so fully does he fulfill and complete the role of Priest that he can even be said to be the temple itself. Again, Jesus Christ is the Priest who represents God ^[394]to us and us to God. But he is not only that—for he so completely represents us to God that he not only makes the sacrifice for sins but indeed *is* the sacrifice for sins on our behalf, and he so completely represents God to us that he makes sacrifice for sins *on God’s behalf* and *as God*.

Third, Jesus Christ is also King. He comes as the fulfillment of the Davidic covenant (2 Sam 7). This theme is central to the gospel portrayals of the life and ministry of Jesus. Consider how the theme of sovereignty is developed in Matthew’s Gospel. Matthew introduces this theme at the outset; even his genealogy presents Jesus as the “son of David” and thus as a royal heir. After this announcement, Matthew immediately introduces tension as the visiting magi come to King Herod and ask for the location of the recently born “king of the Jews.” John the Baptist initiates the public ministry of Jesus not only with a prophetic call to repentance but also with the announcement, “Repent, for the kingdom of heaven has come near” (Matt 3:2). Following his baptism, Jesus is led by the Spirit into the desert where he faces intense temptation, and here the issue of sovereignty is precisely at the center of the struggle: Who can command, and who is worthy of worship? (Matt 4:1–11). Much of Jesus’s teaching revolves around the “kingdom of heaven” (e.g., Matt 5:3), and when he teaches his followers how to pray, he lists prayer for the coming of the kingdom as the first petition (Matt 6:10). Jesus’s parables continually reference the kingdom (e.g., Matt 25:1), and tension builds as he announces that he will be the final judge of all the nations (Matt 25:31–46). When arrested and brought to trial, he is asked whether he is “King of the Jews” (Matt 27:11). When he is beaten, he has a crown of thorns pressed into his scalp as his tormentors kneel before him in savage mockery saying “Hail, King of the Jews” (Matt 27:29). And he dies—his body stretched on a cross in utter agony—under the sign that says, “This is Jesus, the King of the Jews” (Matt 27:37).

But the sign over the cross is not the last word on sovereignty in the gospel account. When Christ meets his followers after his resurrection, they hear these words: “All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Go therefore and make disciples” (Matt 28:18–19). He indeed is “King of the Jews”—but he is so much more than that. He is the King of the entire cosmos. As Abraham Kuyper says, “There is not one square inch in the whole domain of our human existence over which Christ, who is Sovereign over *all*, does not cry: ‘Mine!’”⁷³

Jesus Christ is the Prophet who announces—and indeed embodies—God’s presence and power. As Prophet, he speaks—and indeed embodies—the truth. As ^[395]Prophet, he brings—and indeed embodies—God’s judgment on sin. As Priest, he represents sinful humans to God and a holy God to humans. As Priest, he not only displays but actually incarnates God’s holiness. As Priest, he not only offers a sacrifice but is himself the sacrifice that is offered. And as Priest, he not only judges unholiness but cleanses and renews and makes sinful people truly holy. As King, he establishes his reign by self-sacrifice and a willingness to suffer on behalf of others—even those who have arrayed themselves against him as his enemies. As King he brings liberation from oppression. As the crucified and resurrected King, his authority is all-encompassing. And unlike all earthly kingdoms, his kingdom will have no end.

In his prophetic, priestly, and regal roles, Christ does for us what we cannot do for ourselves. In his vocation as Prophet, Christ teaches and guides and warns. He not only teaches with words; he lives out his life in an exemplary way. As Peter says, “Christ also suffered for you, leaving you an example, so that you should

follow in his steps” (1 Pet 2:21). John sharpens the point: “Whoever says, ‘I abide in him,’ ought to walk just as he walked” (1 John 2:6).

In his priestly work, Christ makes clear that he has come to be a substitute and sacrifice for sinners. He says that he has “not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life a ransom for many” (Mark 10:45 NIV). Paul says that God offered him “as a sacrifice of atonement by his blood, effective through faith” (Rom 3:25); he was “handed over to death for our trespasses and was raised for our justification” (Rom 4:25). For “in Christ God was reconciling the world to himself, not counting their trespasses against them” because “for our sake” he made the one “who knew no sin” to be an offering for sin, “so that in him we might become the righteousness of God” (2 Cor 5:19, 21). Jesus Christ’s death on the cross was “the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all” (Heb 10:10). Peter tells us that “he himself bore our sins in his body on the cross, so that, free from sins, we might live for righteousness; by his wounds you have been healed” (1 Pet 2:24). For “Christ also suffered for sins once for all, the righteous for the unrighteous, in order to bring you to God” (1 Pet 3:18).

And in his work as sovereign King, he defeats the powers of evil and establishes justice and righteousness. As if anticipating the question—Why would God become incarnate?—Paul says that “God made you alive together with [Christ], when he forgave us all our trespasses, erasing the record that stood against us with its legal demands. He set this aside, nailing it to the cross. He disarmed the rulers and authorities and made a public example of them, triumphing over them in it” (Col 2:13b–15). John echoes this same theme: “The Son of God was revealed for this purpose, to destroy the works of the devil” (1 John 3:8b).

^[396]Far from an idiosyncratic vision of Christ’s saving work, the *munus triplex* or threefold office is endorsed in every major Protestant tradition. For instance, **it is clearly taught in both the Heidelberg Catechism and the Westminster Shorter Catechism.** Aware of this broad and strong support in official Protestant teaching, John Wesley insists that the threefold office is an essential part of what “a true Protestant believes,” saying, “I believe that Jesus of Nazareth was the Savior of the world, the Messiah so long foretold; that, being anointed with the Holy Ghost, He was a Prophet, revealing to us the whole will of God; that He was a Priest who gave Himself a sacrifice for sin, and still makes intercession for transgressors; that He is a King, who has all power in heaven and in earth, and will reign till He has subdued all things to Himself.”⁷⁴

In summary, we can see that Christ’s identity as both fully human and fully divine in the unity of his person is very closely connected to his mission and work. His very being as the eternally divine Son who is also human is key to his work of making at-one-ment—for in him humanity and divinity are united, and in him we have proof that human nature is not foreign to the holiness of God. He is the second Adam, the new beginning of humanity. As the ancient church loved to say, he *recapitulates* or re-heads humanity. Paul identifies Jesus Christ as the preexistent agent of creation; Jesus is the one who is “before all things” and the “firstborn of all creation,” the one who is the Creator of “all things in heaven and on earth . . . visible and invisible” (Col 1:15–17). But not only is he the “firstborn of all creation”; he is also the “firstborn from the dead,” the one who has defeated death and brings new life to all who are joined in union with him (Col 1:18). Make no mistake—he is fully divine: “In him all the fullness of God was pleased to dwell” (Col 1:19). And “through him” God was also pleased “to reconcile to himself all things, whether on earth or in heaven, by making peace through the blood of his cross” (Col 1:20).

9.7. The Sufficient and Ongoing Nature of Christ's Saving Work

In Jesus Christ, God has overcome every obstacle or barrier that stands in the way of our enjoying communion with him and with one another in him. He has confronted and defeated both the reality and the guilt of sin as well as the consequences of sin,^[397] namely, death itself. He has even dealt a decisive blow to the devil. And he has done so in person. As the Nicene Creed declares, all that Christ does, from incarnation to resurrection and beyond, is “for us and for our salvation.” And it is enough. Christ has done everything necessary for our salvation. His saving work is sufficient. We cannot and need not do anything ourselves that would add to what he has done. Whatever our debts, whatever our shortcomings, whatever the consequences of our sin, whatever the price—Jesus has paid it all. This is a foundational scriptural principle. It is also a hallmark of classical Christian and Protestant theology.

It is one thing to register the sufficiency of Christ's work for our salvation; it is another thing to keep it squarely in view. Wesleyans and other Pietist groups are particularly prone to move too quickly from what Christ has done for us to what the Holy Spirit is doing in us and through us. To the extent that we do so, we come by it honestly. John Wesley himself was primarily interested in the affective dimensions of soteriology, which is to say, in the doctrines of regeneration, sanctification, and Christian perfection. These were his long suits as a theologian.⁷⁵ Comparatively speaking, Wesley spends far more time discussing our *subjective appropriation* of Christ's work than he does discussing the work itself.

Why is this a problem? In one sense, it isn't. Indeed, we need to be careful not to lose touch with the Pietist and revivalist aspects of our tradition. Woe be unto us if we trade our warmed hearts for dead orthodoxy! At the same time, Wesley's emphasis on our subjective appropriation of the saving benefits of Christ's work has sometimes led, albeit unintentionally, to what Phillip Cary has called a culture of “anxious narcissism.”⁷⁶ When asked the question, “What is your faith about?” we respond by making it fundamentally about ourselves. We make it as much or more about what we have done or what we need to do than about what Christ has done “for us and for our salvation.” In the process, we risk losing sight of the sufficiency of Christ's saving work.

The emphasis on subjective appropriation is not limited to one strand of the Wesleyan tradition. On the contrary, we can observe it in every expression of contemporary Wesleyan Christianity. For example, evangelical Wesleyans have historically placed heavy emphasis on the need for repentance and on the importance of accepting Jesus Christ as one's personal Lord and Savior. To be sure, these actions—repentance and profession of faith—presuppose prior actions on God's^[398] part. Yet, in evangelical Wesleyan circles, the focus can easily shift from what Jesus Christ has done once and for all “for us and for our salvation” to what we must do to be saved. Anxious narcissism occurs because, unlike God's decisive and irreversible action in Jesus Christ on our behalf, human repentance and profession of faith are always subject to scrutiny, self-doubt, wavering, backsliding, and the like. Thus, evangelical Wesleyans can be plagued by the following questions: Were we sincere enough in our repentance? Were our motives pure? Did we really put our full trust in Jesus? Have we really given God our whole hearts, or are we holding back a part of ourselves? Is our faith strong enough? Can we lose our salvation? In the worst cases, preoccupation with such questions can be spiritually disabling. Our narcissism and anxiety can subtly undermine our confidence and simple trust in what Christ has done for us.

Liberal-progressive expressions of the Wesleyan tradition do not fare better. Instead of repentance and personal faith, the focus here is on social justice or social reform. Anxious narcissism occurs because we are given to scrutinizing and doubting our own efforts to combat the many forms of social injustice in the world. Social evils like racism and sexism, we are told, inhere in societal structures and are virtually impossible to eradicate. We can never repent enough or do enough to bring about real and permanent change. Here, too, questions abound: Have we sufficiently condemned racism, sexism, and other social injustices? Have we sufficiently confronted social injustice in our workplaces? In our churches? In our homes? In what ways do we

ourselves remain complicit in social injustice? Standing up to social injustices is important, but we must be careful that preoccupation with our efforts to eliminate injustice does not cause us to lose sight of what Christ has done “for us and for our salvation.”

Rightly understood, Christ’s saving work in its totality—and his suffering and death on the cross in particular—should be a bulwark against anxious narcissism. Unfortunately, that is not always the case. Thus, George Lindbeck notes how easily our focus can shift from Christ’s saving work on the cross to our subjective appropriation of its saving benefits: “Those who continued to use the *sola fide* language assumed that they agreed with the reformers no matter how much, under the influence of conversionist pietism and revivalism, they turned the faith that saves into a meritorious good work of the free will, a voluntaristic decision to believe that Christ bore the punishment of sins on the cross *pro me*, for each person individually. Improbable as it might seem given the metaphor (and the Johannine passage from which it comes), everyone is thus capable of being ‘born again’ if only he or she tries hard enough.”⁷⁷

^[399]To make matters worse, much contemporary theological reflection on the atonement shifts the emphasis away from the question, What has Jesus done? to the question, What would Jesus do? To be sure, the latter question is not illegitimate or unimportant. In fact, we can hear in it a version of the moral exemplar and influence motif discussed above. However, if taken by itself, this motif and this question (What would Jesus do?) can obscure what is even more fundamental to the Christian faith, namely, what Christ has done for us. As Colin Gunton observes, “in place of an act of God” centered in the “historic life and death” of Jesus “towards the otherwise helpless,” the emphasis is now on “those who by appropriate action [can] help themselves.”⁷⁸

None of this is to say that we should not heed the New Testament’s repeated commands to repent, to put our faith in Christ, to obey Christ’s commandments, and so on. On the contrary, there is a time and a place to emphasize precisely these things. More specifically, there is a time and place to stress all the Holy Spirit does in us and through us to administer the saving benefits of Christ’s work. For that matter, there is a time and a place to emphasize the importance of our cooperation (synergism) with the Spirit’s transforming work. However, all these things must be kept in the proper place. Otherwise, we can too easily succumb to anxious narcissism. Good dogmatic order and discipline matter. Without it we end up talking primarily about ourselves.

Speaking of good dogmatic order and discipline, no one in the Wesleyan theological tradition exemplifies it more than William Burt Pope. Christology is not just central to Pope’s theology; it is its controlling norm. Both in his person and in the Scriptures (which are “under the control and supervision of the Holy Spirit”), Jesus Christ simply is God’s self-revelation to humanity. As such, the first question that theology must answer is not a question about our response to the coming of God in Christ. Rather, it is a question about what the revelation of God in Christ tells us about God’s eternal nature and purposes.

When Pope says that Jesus Christ is the revelation of God, he does so with the suffering and death of Christ specifically in mind. In other words, he doesn’t begin with a conception of deity in the abstract, which is to say, deity conceived entirely apart from God’s concrete actions in Christ. Rather, Christ’s incarnation and especially his work on the cross stand at the center of Pope’s Christology, governing all that comes before and after. Put simply, they are the key for understanding God’s ^[400]eternal nature and purposes. Thus, Pope says, “Before the world existed, Christ was ordained to take human nature” for its renewal.⁷⁹

That Pope is clearly aware of the dangers of moving too quickly from Christ’s saving work to our personal appropriation of the benefits that it secures is evident in the following declaration: “Redemption is in the New Testament declared to have been a purpose of God in or from eternity. This design, having reference *solely* to the Saviour’s work, and *apart from its application by the Spirit*, is regarded in Scripture as an absolute decree of man’s salvation virtually accomplished from the beginning: a mystery reserved for gradual revelation, but a reality underlying all human history.”⁸⁰

For Pope, Christ's saving work reflects God's eternal nature and purposes. It tells us who God really is. Thus, Pope goes on to say, "But, in the mystery of the Atonement, the provision of eternal mercy, as it were, anticipates the transgression, and love in every representation of it has the pre-eminence. The passion is the exhibition rather than the cause of the Divine love to man."⁸¹

When our gaze slips, however unintentionally, from Christ's saving work, we can be prone to forget not only what Christ has done "for us and for our salvation" but also what his work tells us about who God is. The Christian God is the God who takes it upon himself to do whatever is necessary to bring about the realization of his wholly good purposes. More than that, the Christian God is the God who realizes his purposes for creation and especially for us creatures in a way that evokes our wonder, love, and praise. He is the God who becomes incarnate, suffers and dies, and who, on the third day, is risen from the dead, so that we might be saved. The Christian God is the God who remains faithful to us even when we deliberately disobey him and destroy the works of his hands.

But the incarnate Word also ascends into heaven (Acts 1:6–11), and he now reigns supreme at the right hand of the Father (Col 3:1). In one sense, his ascension represents the completion of his saving mission. After all, from the cross, he cries out, "It is finished" (John 19:30). However, people still struggle against sin, death, and the devil. As Eleonore Stump says, there is the "problem of past sin" and the "problem of future sin."⁸² In other words, there is the problem of what we have done, but we are also faced with the reality that, despite what Christ^[401] has done once and for all, he appears to have left us with the unwelcome but undeniable reality that we continue to do bad things and cause harm to one another and to ourselves. Thus, we must ask, How does Christ's saving work address both problems?

For the most part, classical views of Christ's work like the ones we have discussed above tend to focus on the problem of "past sin." They do not always get articulated in ways that speak to the ever-present reality of sin, evil, and suffering in the world. One option here would be simply to point to ourselves. If the world is going to change, then we will have to be the ones to do it. To use a common expression, we are "Christ's only hands and feet in the world."

Despite this expression's popularity, it is deeply problematic. Above all, it risks obscuring Christ's ongoing agency and saving action on our behalf. For despite Christ's declaration, "It is finished," the Scriptures also make it clear that Christ is not finished acting on our behalf. His work on the cross may be finished, but his saving work is not. Christ's ascension and session at the right hand of the Father do not amount to his absence from the world or a cessation of his saving work.⁸³ Why not? If Christ is seated at the right hand of the Father, then how can his saving presence and work on our behalf be said to continue?

In the New Testament, Christ's ascension does not signal the end of his saving work. On the contrary, Scripture shows that Christ's saving work is ongoing in at least two significant ways. First, Christ is shown to be interceding "for us." Paul tells us that Jesus is seated at the right hand of the Father where he "intercedes for us" (Rom 8:34). And the book of Hebrews exclaims that Christ "always lives to make intercession" for us (Heb 7:25). Clearly inspired by these verses, Charles Wesley captures the ongoing nature of Christ's saving work in his magnificent hymn, "Arise, My Soul, Arise!" Combining the motifs of sacrifice and ransom, Charles develops an unforgettable image of the ascended Christ's bleeding wounds offering prayers on our behalf.

Arise, my soul, arise, shake off the guilty fears
The bleeding Sacrifice in my behalf appears
Before the throne my Surety stands
Before the throne my Surety stands
My name is written on His hands.

^[402]He ever lives above for me to intercede
His all-redeeming love, His precious blood to plead
His blood atoned for every race
His blood atoned for every race
And sprinkles now the throne of grace.

Five bleeding wounds He bears received on Calvary
They pour effectual prayers, they strongly plead for me
“Forgive him, O forgive,” they cry
“Forgive him, O forgive,” they cry
“Nor let that ransomed sinner die!”⁸⁴

Wesley’s hymn is a stunning reminder that, while Christ’s work on the cross is finished, he is not finished with us. Even now, Christ is interceding for us. He is praying for us. And through this ongoing work, he remains present with us, just as he promised he would.

Second, seated at the right hand of the Father, Christ is absent “in the flesh.” But he is not absent altogether. Nor is he present *only* through intercessory prayer. Before he left his disciples and ascended to his Father, Jesus promised that he will send “another Comforter” or “Advocate” (John 14:16). When his disciples are saddened by the news that he will leave them, Jesus tells them that it is for *their good* or to their advantage for him to go away (John 16:7). Thus, in addition to interceding for us, Christ’s presence and saving work continue in the unifying work of the Holy Spirit, who just is the Spirit of Christ.

Finally, as we will see up ahead, even the outpouring of the Holy Spirit does not exhaust or complete Christ’s saving work. On the contrary, Christ’s saving work will be truly finished only when he comes again in glory to judge the living and the dead. As the ancient liturgical formula known simply as the “mystery of faith” declares, “Christ has died, Christ is risen, Christ will come again.”

We will take up the second coming of our Lord in the final chapter of this work. For now, we must turn our attention to the mysterious reality about whom Christ himself spoke on the eve of his crucifixion—the person of the Holy Spirit.